

Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

ASSAM: MOLTEN METAL FALLS ON WORKERS AFTER BLAST, 4 KILLED

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SILCHAR: At least four people were killed and two injured on Sunday after an explosion at a metal processing unit in Assam's Cachar district spilled molten metal on workers, police said.

According to police, the explosion occurred at around 11am at Kade Global Infrastructure LLP's metal processing unit at Pangram in the Udhlabond constituency.

The families of the victims and local residents demanded a thorough investigation into the incident, alleging that multiple explosions had occurred at the unit in the past.

2 DIE IN NOIDA SEWAGE TANK AFTER INHALING TOXIC FUMES

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NOIDA: Two men, including a contractor cleaning a sewage treatment plant (STP) tank and a security guard who tried to rescue him, died after allegedly inhaling toxic gases at a housing society in Noida's Sector 150 on Sunday, police said.

Police said the incident took place around 3:30am at the residential society. It was not clear why the contractor was carrying out the cleaning at this hour. A case has been registered and four people from the society have been detained in connection with the matter, police said.

DELHI MAN DIES OF ELECTROCUTION WHILE CONNECTING PUMP'S WIRING

NEW DELHI: A 39-year-old carpenter died after being electrocuted while connecting the electrical wiring of a water pump connected to a water tanker in south Delhi's Tigris area on Saturday, police said on Sunday.

"Preliminary investigation suggests the electrocution was caused by faulty wiring attached to the water pump, and not the tanker," an officer said. "We are further ascertaining whether the tanker belonged to the Delhi Jal Board or a private agency."

1 DEAD, 26 INJURED AFTER PRIVATE BUS OVERTURNS ON KERALA HIGHWAY

MALAPPURAM: A private bus on the Kozhikode-Thiruvananthapuram route overturned on the highway in Malappuram district of Kerala on Sunday morning, killing one person and injuring 26 others, police officers aware of the details said.

The exact cause of the accident is yet to be established. However, a senior police officer said investigators suspect the bus was speeding and that wet road conditions due to rain may also have played a role.

Water supply affected in parts of Delhi due to leak in Munak Canal

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NEW DELHI: Several parts of north and south-west Delhi continued to face severe water shortage on Sunday, with residents reporting dry taps for 48 to 72 hours after a leak in the Munak Carrier Line Canal (CLC) Canal disrupted the capital's main raw water supply on Friday.

Residents from Rohini, Dwarka, Palam, Uttam Nagar, Hari Nagar, Anand, Naraina, Nangloi and Barai complained of prolonged disruptions, with many saying they had not received any prior notice. The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) officials said the damaged stretch of the

PM unveils Nilekani-led panel for exam reforms

Sanjay Maurya and
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced a six-member high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend technological interventions and structural reforms to overhaul the National Testing Agency's (NTA) examination system.

The announcement came a day after the resignation of Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan following the 36-day student agitation over irregularities in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NET) and a day before the government is set to introduce a bill in Parliament providing for imprisonment of up to 10 years and fines of up to ₹10 crore for those convicted of paper leaks.

In a video message first posted on Instagram, Modi said the government had already established fast-track courts to try examination malpractice cases and was moving to strengthen the NTA's internal security, but said broader reforms were needed to restore confidence in the examination system.

"Our examination system needs to be reliable and transparent, and it must make maximum use of technology. Keeping all these factors in mind, we have decided to constitute a high-powered task force under the leadership of the world-renowned technology expert Nandan Nilekani. This task force will focus on examination reforms, and based on its report, steps will be taken to ensure the credibility of upcoming examinations at the earliest," he said.

Apart from Nilekani, the panel will comprise former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) chairman S. Somnath, former Intelligence Bureau director Tapan De, Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Mumbai's former director, and



(Top) NDMC workers repaint a wall at the Jantar Mantara a day after the BJP called off its protest; and Union minister Pralhad Joshi chairs a meeting after taking additional charge of the education ministry in Delhi on Sunday.

Cleaners to guards: The volunteers who wore many hats to power stir

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NEW DELHI: Groups of young people transformed into cleaners, medics, security guards, cooks, artists and organisers, without ever being asked, to help keep the protest at Jantar Mantar running smoothly.

Some sweet rain-soaked pavements littered with disposable plates and water bottles from the previous night. Others unloaded cartons of donated food. Tea was

NOBODY ASSIGNED THEM THESE JOBS. PEOPLE LOOKED AROUND, BEGAN DOING WHATEVER THEY FELT NEEDED TO BE DONE.

Some poured into paper cups. Breakfast packets changed hands. A small medical camp arranged medicines while volunteers adjusted loudspeakers and

'THOUGHT I'D LOSE MY ARM', PELLET VICTIM RECOUNTS

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NEW DELHI: Prashant, 25, on Sunday said he thought he would lose his arm after allegedly suffering pellet injuries during clashes between police personnel and protesters on July 20. He was treated at the Lady Harding Hospital. His discharge paper, accessed by HT, reads: "Multiple pellet injuries to the right upper limb, chest and inguinal region."

CALM, CLEANUP AT GROUND ZERO OF STUDENT PROTEST

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NEW DELHI: A day after the BJP-led student protest was called off, Jantar Mantar, where slogans echoed for weeks, fell silent. On Sunday, the area remained off-limits to the public, with barricades still in place and cleaning operations underway. Nearby markets, which had fallen quiet during the stir, showed signs of returning to normal.

2 Indians missing after ship struck in Black Sea

Yogesh Naik and
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MUMBAI/NEW DELHI: Two Indian seamen went missing after jumping into the Black Sea when their Palau-flagged cargo ship, MV AGN Ragnar, was attacked by three drones on Saturday evening while exiting the Bystre Mouth of the Danube River, according to the Directorate of Maritime Administration.

The missing crew members, Chandra Ram Dubey and Deepak Kumar Gupta, remain untraced. The remaining seven crew members, including two other Indian nationals, along with the pilot, were safely evacuated ashore by the Ukrainian Coast Guard.

Search and rescue operations were launched but had to be suspended because of the continuing drone threat. The opera-

TWO SEAFARERS JUMPED INTO THE WATER AFTER THEIR CARGO SHIP WAS ATTACKED BY THREE DRONES

The latest attack follows two similar incidents in the Black Sea since mid-July that claimed the lives of five Indian seafarers.

On July 18, MV Omori, a Saint Kitts and Nevis-registered cargo vessel, was struck by two drones at about 20m from the shore while transiting the Black Sea. The vessel had 10 crew members, including three Indian nationals. Chief Officer Sagar Gupta, an Indian national,

was killed, while the other two Indian crew members were reported safe.

A day later, MV Golden Leo, a cargo vessel with mostly Indian and Syrian crew members, was hit by three Russian missiles in the Black Sea, killing 10 people. At the time of the attack, the vessel had 17 crew members and a Ukrainian pilot on board. The crew comprised five Indian nationals and 12 Syrian nationals.

The bodies of two Indian seafarers - Chief Officer Akhil Jovan and Ordinary Seaman Abhishek Nishad - have been identified. The remaining eight recovered bodies were severely burnt and are yet to be identified through the prescribed process, according to the Directorate of Maritime Administration.

The four Indian seafarers on continued on 97

US, Iran halt attacks for second day amid renewed truce efforts

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CAIRO: The US paused its attacks on Iran for a second straight day Sunday and Tehran said it had done so too, as efforts continued to bring the countries back to negotiations on an interim ceasefire deal largely undermined by recent exchanges of fire.

It was not clear why the US has paused after targeting Iran's coastal areas and infrastructure in a nearly two-week escalation sparked by Iran's firing of ships trying to transit the Strait of Hormuz. The Pentagon did not immediately respond to questions Sunday.

US President Donald Trump is "giving talks some space. He's giving it a little bit of room," Mike Waltz, the US ambassador

AN OFFICIAL SAID BOTH COUNTRIES WANT TO RETURN TO THE INTERIM CEASEFIRE DEAL SIGNED IN JUNE

to the United Nations, told Fox News. "We've had both Oman and Iran, and a number of our other negotiators, engaged at every level, from the most senior levels all the way down to the technical level over the past few weeks, and particularly in the past few days."

Since the US has halted attacks for the past two nights, Iran has as well, its army spokesman told Iran's state TV on Sunday.

IRAN VOWS RESPONSE TO UKRAINIAN ATTACK ON SHIP IN CASPIAN SEA

Iran's foreign minister Abbas Araghchi on Sunday warned that his country would respond to a deadly attack by Ukraine on an Iranian ship in the Caspian Sea. It came after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said Kyiv had carried out strikes against vessels transporting military cargo involving Iran. "Zelensky has attacked an Iranian commercial vessel, killing a sailor," Araghchi said on X, describing it as a "blatant UN Charter violation done in Iran's behalf to drag Europe into its war." He said that, during calls with the EU's Kaja Kallas and Russian top diplomat Sergei Lavrov, he "made clear that what the freelancer in Kyiv did CANNOT GO UNANSWERED."

Siddaramaiah rules out contesting polls, cites health, 'corrupt politics'

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Former Karnataka chief minister and veteran Congress leader Siddaramaiah announced on Sunday that he will not contest any elections in future, including the 2028 state assembly polls, citing advancing age, declining health and politics becoming "corrupt".

The 79-year-old, however, said he will remain active in politics and continue speaking on issues affecting the public.

"Since the political field has become corrupted today, I will not contest the 2028 assembly elections. However, remaining active in politics, I will continue to stand as a voice for the people's hardships and joys," Siddaramaiah said in a post in Kannada on X, detailing what he had said at a private event in Mandya district on Saturday.

CABINET EXPANSION IN K'TAKA LIKELY THIS WK

Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar will travel to New Delhi on Monday for meetings with the Congress leadership, including former CM Siddaramaiah and Karnataka unit president BK Hariprasad to likely finalise the list of candidates for 20 vacant ministries. A meeting of senior party leaders is scheduled for Monday evening, and, according to leaders familiar with the discussions, the expansion could be announced as early as Tuesday or Wednesday.

STRESSING THAT THE PEOPLE OF THE VARUNA CONSTITUENCY ARE URGING HIM TO CONTEST THE POLLS, HE SAID:

"He has decided that I should not contest in any elections henceforth." He added: "I am now 79 years old. My health is not as robust as it used to be."

THREE KILLED AS DOUBLE-DECKER BUS FLIPS OVER IN SAMBALH DISTRICT

HT Correspondent
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MEERUT: A double-decker bus travelling from Uttar Pradesh's Bahraich to Punjab overturned in Sambhal district early on Sunday, killing three passengers and injuring nine others. At least 25, police said, adding that preliminary enquiries indicate that the driver may have dozed off, causing the vehicle to hit the central divider and overturn.

CABINET SECRETARY TO BUREAUCRATS: SHED 'PLAYING SAFE' APPROACH

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NEW DELHI: Cabinet secretary TV Somanathan has asked senior bureaucrats to shed "playing safe" approach and delegate greater authority to junior civil servants, emphasising that excessive centralisation can slow government functioning, overwhelm senior officers and deprive garden composites in the Berlin suburb of Spandau.

1 KILLED IN BERLIN PRIDE FEST ATTACK, SUSPECT SHOT DEAD DURING POLICE OP

BERLIN: A man allegedly drove a van into a crowd near the Berlin Pride festival on Saturday, killing one person, injuring several people before, apparently stabbing others with a machete in what German authorities believe was an Islamic extremist terror attack. The suspect in the attack was shot and killed on Sunday during a police operation at an allotment garden complex in the Berlin suburb of Spandau.

SOORYAVANSHI NAMED PLAYER OF SERIES AS INDIA DOMINATE ZIM

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KOLKATA: Yashvir Sooryavanshi hit a mature fifty and Yashvir Yadav took 3/29 to headline India's comfortable 35-run victory against Zimbabwe in the third T20I at Harare on Sunday for a 3-0 series sweep.

Sooryavanshi's 81 off 49 balls was the cornerstone of India's 192 that proved comfortably above par on a surface where stroke-making became progressively harder. With 151 runs, the teenager was declared Player of the Series.

{ THIRD GOLD AT CWG }

Gold standard Mirabai raises the bar once again, finishes on top with record-breaking performance

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NEW DELHI: A brief hiccup notwithstanding, there was a degree of preordained certainty about Mirabai Chanu as she stepped up to the barbell at the SEC Armadillo in Glasgow on Sunday.

Having begun her Commonwealth Games journey in the Scottish city in 2014, when she won silver as a 19-year-old, Chanu has since become the undisputed queen of Indian weightlifting, winning every major medal there is - except at the Asian Games - and cementing her legacy in Indian sport. The Commonwealth Games, the snafu record fell first, then the clean and jerk, setting a



Mirabai Chanu after a successful lift during the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Sunday.

Gold Coast (2018) and Birmingham (2022).

Standing atop the podium, Chanu yelled up, "Watching the national anthem made me a little emotional. They were tears of joy because I had won the first gold medal for India at these Games," she said. Having moved down to the 48kg category, Chanu also revealed the struggle of making weight. "When I used to compete in 49kg, I didn't have to be quite as strict with weight control, but 48kg is a real battle. Maintaining that body weight is a huge challenge. Since this was my last Commonwealth Games in 48kg, I told myself I could do it," she said.

The platform with multiple reverts in the 48kg division. The snatch record fell first, then the clean and jerk, setting a new mark for the total lift. The victory completed her hat-trick of gold at the Commonwealth Games, following triumphs in

NUMBER THEORY

Youth's population share peaked earlier but aspirations still rising

By Abhishek Jha and Roshan Kishore

Indian politics has always been highly sensitive to students' protests. There is good historical reason for it. Much of the country's current political leadership, especially those who came of age opposing the Congress, can trace the roots of their political careers to the anti-Emergency movement of the 1970s. While multiple forces came together to unseat the Congress for the first time in 1977, students' protests played a critical role. Many of those protestors went on to become prominent political leaders.

With the protests over the NEET paper leaks that concluded on Saturday, the question is back in focus: how important can students and their larger demographic cohort, the so-called Gen Z — those born after 1996 or under 30 years in 2026 — be in shaping Indian politics today? Here is what the data shows.



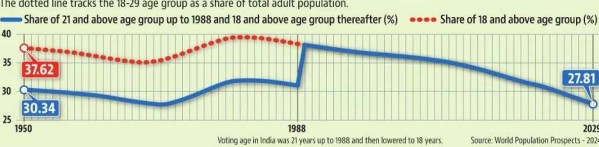
1 As a share of voters, importance of 18-29 age group is declining

This age group accounts for a substantial 29% of India's voting age population in 2026, according to United Nations projections, and is expected to account for around 28% even in 2029. But this is not the largest electoral presence the cohort has had in independent India. Since 1950, its highest share in the 18-and-above population came in 1980, when their share was 39.5%. In 1977, the year when India elected its first non-Congress

government after the Emergency, and when a lot of current BJP leaders were youth leaders, and when leaders such as Narendra Modi were in the 18-29 age cohort, the share of this age group was 38.9%. This number is the ninth-highest in the 1950-2029 period, but was at its highest and still rising at that time. To be sure, the voting age at the time was 21 years, but the share of the 21-29 age group was also still the highest until then and expanding.

Share of youth in voting age population

The solid line tracks the share of youngest voters (up to the age of 29) in the total voting age population. The dotted line tracks the 18-29 age group as a share of total adult population.



2 As a share of overall population, Gen Z and its younger peers are a smaller group than other age groups

Annual population estimates and projections by the UN show this clearly. Indian demographic today has a much larger share of the population which is at least 30 years old or above. This means that in pure demographic terms, the political weight of young voters or younger prospective voters is significantly smaller than it has ever been in the past.

Share of different age groups in India's population



3 To be sure, there are widespread regional differences in this trend

Those who are aware of India's geographical demographic divergence will not be surprised. In Bihar, the 18-29 age group's share in voters is still as high as it was in India during the Emergency. In Tamil Nadu, the number is significantly lower, just above one in five. That said, recent elections in Tamil Nadu

suggest that what the younger voters perhaps lacked in numbers, they compensated for in persuasion. The state elected a debutant political party formed by a film star with large following among younger voters, who, if anecdotal evidence is to be believed, persuaded their parents to vote for him.

Share of 18-29 age group in 2026 population



4 But what could be significantly higher for the Gen Z is aspirations

India of 2026 is significantly more urban, educated, and wealthy than it was in the mid-1970s. Census and government survey data, while patchy, shows this clearly. The share of the 20-29 year old population which are graduates has increased drastically in the more recent past. In 1991 only 5.9% of the age group had finished college with at least a graduate degree. This number increased to 12.8% by the

2011 census and could now be as high as 26.5% if recent survey-based estimates from the government are to be believed. Education also means that this generation of younger voters believe that they deserve better in their professional lives. With education not translating into good job opportunities, they are becoming angry. While their share might have fallen in India's population, their absolute number has only increased.

{ WORLD } PUSH FOR FEDERAL VOTER LIST

US court upholds block on Trump mail-in voting order



A federal appeals court has upheld a ruling that in nearly half of US states halted President Donald Trump's executive order to create a federal list of eligible voters and limit delivery of mail ballots only to people on that list. Trump issued an executive order in March for the director of US Citizenship and Immigration Services and commissioner of the Social Security Administration to create a 'state citizenship list' of eligible voters. While Trump touted the proposed changes as safeguards to keep non-US citizens from voting, state election officials argued they were ripe for abuse and could cause chaos.

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SILCHAR: Sixty-year-old Noor Jahan from Assam's Morigaon spent seven years in a foreigners' detention centre after a Foreigners Tribunal (FT) declared her an illegal foreigner in an ex-parte (one-sided) order in 2011. Her husband, Abdul Jebbar, 75, was declared a foreigner by the same quasi-judicial tribunal in 2012.

Arrested in 2013, the elderly couple walked out only in 2020 during the Covid-19 lockdown after the Supreme Court (SC) ordered the release of long-term detainees on conditional bail.

The family is modest. Noor Jahan is a housewife, and Abdul Jebbar served as a cleric at a mosque in Tezpur until his arrest. But their challenge to their detention — first in front of the Gauhati high court in 2013 which was dismissed four months later and then before the Supreme Court in 2017 — became part of a historic apex court order earlier this month involving 27 Assam residents declared foreigners through similar proceedings.

"I cannot forget the night when we were almost dragged by the police. We were among many families, and they (the police) were treating us like we were not humans but some domestic cows," Noor Jahan said.

She said family members tried to show their documents to police officers but the officers refused to check. "My father's name appeared in the 1951 National Register of Citizens (NRC), he had voted as an Indian multiple times before 1966, and we have all the documents. We tried to show those, but nobody listened to us," she added.

The FT notice was issued in early 2009, and the couple appeared twice before the tribunal.

However, due to a miscommunication with their lawyer, they did not receive updates about subsequent hearing dates, according to Noor Jahan's sons. They were declared foreigners in mid-2012, and around seven months later, on March 26, 2013, filed a writ petition before the Gauhati high court.

In 2016, they approached advocate Milan Laskar, who represented them before the Supreme Court.

Laskar confirmed that Noor Jahan's father Abdul Khalek's name appeared in the NRC 1951 draft and that she had the document in her possession.

"As per the records, she accepted the FT notice and appeared once or twice but later discontinued. They were declared foreigners in an ex-parte order," he said.

Her son, Umar Faruk, said they spent more than ₹12 lakh on the legal process. "The process in the

high court and Supreme Court was highly expensive, and we had to sell our land, cows, and what-ever valuables we had," he said.

"We are five brothers, and two of us were minors when our parents were arrested. They left their studies and joined work so that we could arrange the lawyers' fees. After 13 years, we finally have a chance to show our documents," he said.

"We are five brothers, and two of us were minors when our parents were arrested. They left their studies and joined work so that we could arrange the lawyers' fees. After 13 years, we finally have a chance to show our documents," he said.

The top court judgment

On July 13, a top court bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta held that even when a person fails to appear before a foreigners tribunal, citizenship cannot be determined through a mechanical or purely technical process. The court remanded all 27 cases to the respective tribunals for fresh adjudication and directed that no coercive action be taken against the appellants until the proceedings conclude.

The judgment did not declare any of the appellants Indian citizens. Instead, it stressed that citizenship disputes, which have grave consequences, must be decided through a process that satisfies constitutional standards of fairness.

"A person proceeded against before a foreigners tribunal may ultimately fail to establish Indian citizenship, but the process by which such determination is made must still satisfy the constitutional requirements of fairness, reasonableness and non-arbitrariness," the court observed.

Assam citizenship timelines

Under the Assam Accord, those who entered Assam before January 1, 1966, are recognised as Indian citizens. Those who arrived between January 1, 1966, and March 24, 1971, can remain in the state after registering as foreigners and become eligible for citizenship after 10 years, without voting rights during that period. Those entering on or after March 25, 1971, are treated as illegal immigrants and are liable to detection and deportation.

In 2018, the NRC was carried out in line with the Assam Accord, using March 24, 1971, as the cut-off date for inclusion. As part of the exercise, applicants had to establish a 'family tree' by proving a legitimate link with their ancestors

COMMONWEALTH GAMES 2026
INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

ATHLETICS	BOWLS
Men's 100m heats	Men's singles Round 5
Guinderd Singh (2.40pm)	Pulul Sonowal vs A Hamada (KEN)
Men's long jump	GYMNASTICS
Qualifying rounds	Women's vault final
M Sreesankar, Lokesh Sathyanathan (3.00pm)	Prithvi Samanta (6.15pm)
Men's 110m hurdles heats	SWIMMING
Tegus Shirse (3.55pm)	Men's 200m butterfly heats
Men's high jump final	Sajan Prakash (3.00pm)
Aadarsh Ram, Sarvesh Kishore, Jagaswin Shankar (7.00pm)	Men's 100m breaststroke 58g heats
Women's shot put F57 final	Swatik Patil (4.26pm)
Shilpa K Shylia, Sharmila (7.05pm)	WEIGHTLIFTING
Men's 100m T38 final	Women's 53kg
Raseshbhai Bhatt, Shreyansh Trivedi (9.27pm)	Apesoni Yadav (5.30pm)
	Women's 58kg
	Bindyarni Devi (8.00pm)
	Men's 79kg
	V Jyaya Babu (12.30am (Tues))

A second chance for 27 Assam residents declared foreigners

differences, typographical mistakes, or inconsistencies in decades-old archival records and legacy documents eventually became the basis for their being declared foreigners.

Among those who approached the apex court were Sahibir Dey, Abhakar Ali, Md Akbar Ali, Abeda Khatun, and Anowara Khatun. Their petitions argued that hypothetical discrepancies in historical records had overshadowed the substantive evidence supporting their citizenship claims.

How the tribunal cases unfolded

In Sahibir Dey's case, the FT declared her and her family foreigners after none of them appeared or filed a written statement. The Gauhati high court later upheld the decision, largely on the ground that they had not participated in the proceedings.

Md Akbar Ali's brother appeared before the tribunal and informed it that Akbar Ali was seriously ill and therefore unable to appear. Despite the exemption, the tribunal proceeded to exile and declared him a foreigner.

Samiran Nessa initially appeared before the tribunal and his case was dismissed. But he later remained absent, resulting in another ex-parte declaration. Abeda Khatun filed a written statement but failed to produce evidence despite being granted opportunities, leading to a similar outcome.

The apex court observed that while ex-parte proceedings are legally permissible, they do not relieve tribunals of their obligation to independently assess the available material before arriving at a conclusion.

"An ex-parte proceeding may dispense with the participation of the absent party, but it does not dispense with objective consideration and meaningful adjudication by the tribunal," the bench said.

Activist Kamal Chakrabarty said that while ex-parte was a legal procedure, its execution in most cases was unjust. "In many cases, the police posted the notice on trees or shops; the person in question didn't even know that they were asked to appear," he told HT.

Invoking the doctrine of audi alteram partem, the principle that every person must have an opportunity to be heard, the court described it as one of the foundational rules of natural justice and a "rule of fair play in action."

For Noor Jahan and Abdul Jebbar, the legal battle that began more than a decade ago is far from over. But after years spent inside a detention centre, repeated court appearances, and a prolonged struggle to establish their identity, they now have something they say they never truly had before — a chance to be heard.

"I am hopeful that we will be able to win this case and return to our country (FT)," Noor Jahan said. "At least, we'll die as Indians."

Pogacar wins record 5th Tour de France

Agence France-Presse

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PARIS: Tadej Pogacar claimed his second consecutive Tour de France title as Mathieu van der Poel won a sensational 21st and final stage around Paris on Sunday.

Pogacar joined Jacques Anquetin, Eddy Merckx, Bernard Hinault and Miguel Indurain as the most successful riders in the history of the Tour. Pogacar had all but secured

finished on the iconic Alpe d'Huez climb. The 27-year-old Slovenian won five stages and had been in yellow since his victory in the Pyrenean sixth stage.

He now has 26 stage victories in total, putting him fourth in the all-time list behind only Eddy Merckx (35), Merckx (34) and Hinault (28).

Pogacar also surpassed both Indurain and Chris Froome for the most days spent wearing the yellow jersey with 70, and trails behind only Hinault (75) and Merckx (96).

He is the youngest rider to have won five Tours, more than a year younger than Merckx was in achieving the same feat, and is the first person to finish on the podium seven years running.

He is also the only rider to have won five Tours, more than a year younger than Merckx was in achieving the same feat, and is the first person to finish on the podium seven years running.

M BENGALURU

'Politics corrupt, won't contest polls anymore'

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BENGALURU: Former Karnataka chief minister and veteran Congress leader Siddaramaiah announced on Sunday that he will not contest any elections in future, including the 2028 state assembly polls, citing advancing age, declining health and politics becoming "corrupted".

The 79-year-old Congress Working Committee (CWC) member, however, asserted he will remain active in politics and continue speaking on issues affecting the public.

"Since the political field has become corrupted today, I will not contest in the 2028 assembly elections. However, remaining active in politics, I will continue to stand as a voice for the people's hardships and joys," Siddaramaiah said in a post in Kannada on X, detailing what he had said at a private event in Mandya district the previous day.

Stressing that the people of the Varuna constituency in Mysuru are urging him to contest the elections once again, he said: "I have decided that I should not contest in any elections henceforth. In the past, when I contested elections, it was the people of the constituency who supported us financially and ensured our victory. But today, such a situation no longer exists."

He added: "I am now 79 years old. Our (Congress) government's term has another year

{ SIDDARAMAIAH } FORMER CM

I am now 79. Our govt's term has another year and a half remaining. By then, I will be 81-82 years old. My health is not as robust as it used to be



and a half remaining. By then, I will be 81-82 years old. My health is not as robust as it used to be. It is no longer possible to work with the same enthusiasm as before."

Siddaramaiah, the longest-serving Karnataka chief minister resigned on May 28, following instructions from the Congress high command, paving the way for DK Shivakumar to take over as CM.

The Congress veteran said he will have completed 50 years of public life by the 2028 assembly polls.

"I began my political career in 1978 as a Taluk Board member. I have seen both victory and defeat, but I have the satisfaction of never acting against the principles I believed in or betraying my conscience," he said. Siddaramaiah said money had become central to contesting elections, leaving little space

for "honest" politics. "The time has come where, if we contest elections, we would have to give money to the people. Politics today is thoroughly corrupted. Honest politics seems to have no leg to stand on. In this backdrop, I have arrived at the decision not to contest in future elections," he said.

He added that his withdrawal from electoral politics would not mark the end of his public life. "For five decades, the people of the state have seen me as one among them and affectionately guided me. This debt weighs on me. Therefore, my future life too will be dedicated to public service," he said.

Before the 2023 assembly polls, Siddaramaiah had announced it to be his last election, but added he would continue to remain in politics thereafter. Separately, Siddaramaiah welcomed Union Education

Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, calling it "a victory for the awakened students and youth of this country" and "a victory of democracy and the Constitution."

He said students who had gathered in Delhi had continued their agitation despite difficult conditions. "Lakhs of students and young people camped in Delhi, braving the scorching sun, rain, hunger and ill health. Even in the face of police brutality, they refused to be provoked and continued their peaceful struggle. Their courage has kindled a new hope across the country," he said.

Siddaramaiah said the resignation alone would not resolve problems in the education sector and argued that his party would continue supporting efforts to protect democracy and the Constitution.

State BJP president BV Vijayendra, however, said Pradhan had resigned voluntarily to prevent Congress from exploiting the student protests for political advantage. He said reports suggesting anti-social elements had infiltrated the agitation, leading to violence that injured police personnel, and added that the Union Government had already taken steps to prevent question paper leaks in competitive examinations. Siddaramaiah served as the CM for two tenures, the first from 2013-2018 and then, after the Congress won in 2023 assembly polls, Siddaramaiah was sworn in for his second term as chief minister.

DKS CALLS MP'S MEET IN DELHI TO DISCUSS DROUGHT SITUATION IN STATE

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BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday said he has called a meeting of union ministers and Members of Parliament from Karnataka in Delhi on July 27, to discuss the drought situation and other issues concerning the state.

He also said that the monsoon session of the state legislature will begin from August 13.

"I have called a meeting of Members of Parliament from Karnataka (in Delhi) tomorrow. We have to make them understand about the drought situation. We will also request them to help us. We have to bring their attention to the situation of our dams, other issues, and also pending projects," Shivakumar said.

Speaking to reporters here, he said the MP's meeting was called so they could raise their voice during in favour of the state, during the ongoing Parliament session.

Shivakumar further said that union ministers would also be requested to attend the meeting, adding that he had already spoken with Pralhad Joshi and V Somanna.

"I have not been able to speak to H D Kumaraswamy and I will request all of them," he said.

Noting that the state legislature session will begin from August 13, the CM said, "After the monsoon session, we will have Independence Day break, and then session will be held for about 10 days."

Cong leaders to meet top brass, Cabinet on agenda

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BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar, along with former CM Siddaramaiah and state Congress president BK Hariprasad, will travel to New Delhi on Monday for a possible meeting with the Congress high command to finalise the list of candidates for the 2026 mid-term elections as part of the long-pending cabinet expansion in the southern state.

A meeting of senior party leaders is scheduled for Monday evening, with leaders familiar with the matter saying it is a much-delayed cabinet expansion could be announced as early as Tuesday or Wednesday.

The exercise comes days before Karnataka's legislature convenes for its monsoon session in the first week of August, leaving the ruling Congress in the state with little room for further delay. Congress general secretary (organisation) KC Venugopal said on Saturday that the expansion could take place at any time.

Shivakumar, who was sworn in as CM along with 13 ministers on June 3, following Siddaramaiah's resignation on May 28, on Sunday said he had convened a meeting of Union ministers and lawmakers from Karnataka in Delhi to discuss the drought situation and other issues concerning the state.

With the sanctioned strength of the Karnataka council of ministers being 34, including the



DK Shivakumar

politicians around 50 years old who have spent roughly two decades building the organisation while also creating space for younger legislators and first time MLAs.

The prospect of such a shift has transformed New Delhi into a destination for aspiring ministers. Newly elected legislators have spent the past several days meeting Shivakumar in Bengaluru before heading to the capital, while supporters in their constituencies have also organised rallies and meetings to reinforce their claims.

Among those eyeing a cabinet berth are Subashan Patel, Basanagowda Turvihal, N T Srinivas, J N Ganesh, Vishwas Vaidya, B B Chimmannaikatti, K Harish Gowda, Ravi Shankar, Prakash Kolivada and Shivaganga Basavanna.

"There is a young team of 20 to 25 new MLAs in the party. We all came to give a message that newbies should also get a chance. We came to politics after struggling due to poverty. If we get a chance, we need encouragement to do good work," J N Ganesh told reporters.

The negotiations extend beyond ministerial appointments. Shivakumar is also weighing whether to create two additional deputy chief minister posts alongside G Parameshwara, a move that leaders believe would ensure wider representation for Lingayats. Scheduled Tribes and backward classes.

DCs won't be held accountable for exam paper leaks, says CM

HT Correspondent
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BENGALURU: As state prepares to recruit more than 72,000 government employees, chief minister DK Shivakumar on Saturday made district administrations directly responsible for protecting the integrity of the examinations, warning deputy commissioners that they will be held accountable for any question paper leak or security lapse.

Addressing a review meeting of officials from nine districts under the Bengaluru regional division, Shivakumar ordered district administrations to ensure complete transparency throughout the recruitment process and tighten oversight at every stage of the examinations. The directive comes as the state begins one of its largest recruitment exercises in recent years, with police and civil service examinations scheduled over the coming weeks.

"Our district papers must be given enhanced security. Every stage, including preparation, printing, distribution and collection of examinations, must be documented. Let the NETET team remain a lesson for everyone. If question papers are leaked, the concerned officials, particularly deputy commissioners, will be held responsible," Shivakumar said.

He also announced that every examination centre would be under camera surveillance to

THE DIRECTIVE COMES AS THE STATE BEGINS ONE OF ITS LARGEST RECRUITMENT EXERCISES, WITH POLICE AND CIVIL SERVICE EXAMS SCHEDULED IN THE COMING WEEKS

deter impersonation and other forms of malpractice. "CCTV cameras will be installed at all examination centres to prevent cheating and impersonation," he said. The warning comes against the backdrop of Karnataka's efforts to restore confidence in its recruitment system after a series of examination scandals over the past several years.

The most prominent incident was the 2021 Police sub-inspector recruitment examination, which was cancelled after investigators alleged question paper leaks, manipulation of marks and fraudulent appointments. The criminal investigation department arrested senior officials, middlemen and candidates during the investigation.

That year, the Karnataka examination commission also cancelled the first division assistant recruitment examination following allegations that question papers had been leaked before the test. The criminal investigation

department separately investigated alleged question paper leaks in the recruitment of assistant professors for government first-grade colleges. Other recruitment examinations conducted by the authority have also been marred by allegations of impersonation, organising cheating and the use of Bluetooth-enabled electronic devices.

The scandals led to the enactment of the Karnataka Public Examination (Measures for Prevention of Corruption and Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act, 2023, which received the Governor's assent in 2024. The law prescribes prison terms of up to 12 years and fines ranging from Rs 15 lakh to Rs 10 crore for offences including question paper leaks, organised cheating and other examination fraud. Offences under the law are cognizable and non-bailable, limited attachment of property permitted to the crime and are triable by designated courts.

Accused in the Congress government in Karnataka of "political hypocrisy", senior BJP leader R Ashoka questioned its national legal system, to which he accused Ananth's vehicle and questioned him over his driving. Manjunath also alerted the police control room about the alleged reckless driving. Enraged by the complaint, Ananth allegedly drove his car towards Manjunath in an apparent attempt to run him over.

Manjunath was thrown onto the bonnet of the vehicle and was forced to cling to it as Ananth continued driving for nearly a kilometre, police said.

During the incident, the vehicle also ran over a stray dog, injuring the animal, they said.

Manjunath's lawyer reached an amicable settlement and chose not to lodge a formal complaint, police said. Police booked him for reckless driving and imposed a fine of Rs 5,000.

MAN DRAGGED ON CAR BONNET OVER ARGUMENT ON RASH DRIVING

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: A cab driver allegedly attempted to run over another cab driver following an argument over rash driving, forcing the latter to cling to the bonnet of the moving car for nearly a kilometre before police stopped the vehicle, police said on Sunday.

The incident took place around 11 pm on Friday in Chowdeshwari Nagar when an accused, identified as Ananth, was allegedly driving recklessly, police said.

According to police, another cab driver, Manjunath, had accepted Ananth's vehicle and questioned him over his driving. Manjunath also alerted the police control room about the alleged reckless driving.

Enraged by the complaint, Ananth allegedly drove his car towards Manjunath in an apparent attempt to run him over. Manjunath was thrown onto the bonnet of the vehicle and was forced to cling to it as Ananth continued driving for nearly a kilometre, police said.

During the incident, the vehicle also ran over a stray dog, injuring the animal, they said.

Manjunath's lawyer reached an amicable settlement and chose not to lodge a formal complaint, police said. Police booked him for reckless driving and imposed a fine of Rs 5,000.

Ex-KPSC chief now faces probe in fraud case

Covercoolly Indresh
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BENGALURU: Former chairman of the Karnataka Public Service Commission, suspended this month over allegations involving the appointment of officers to government posts, is facing a fresh criminal investigation after police registered a case against him and others of manipulating the recruitment of veterinary officers through favouritism, bribery and examination fraud, officials said on Sunday.

The Vidhana Soudha police have registered an FIR against former KPSC chairman Shivraj Shankarappa Sahukar, certain examination members and others following a complaint by veterinary officer Manjunath, who alleged that appointments to 400 veterinary officer posts were rigged to benefit relatives and candidates who allegedly paid money to secure government jobs.

The latest case came to Sahukar's legal troubles. Earlier this month, Governor Thawar Chand Gehlot suspended him as KPSC chairman after complaints alleged that he had facilitated the

arappa Sahukar, certain KPSC members and others. The investigation is in preliminary stage, and all aspects of the complaint, including documentary and digital evidence, are being examined. Appropriate legal action will be taken based on the findings of the investigation," he told HT.

Shivraj Shankarappa Sahukar

appointment of his two daughters as industrial extension officers despite a conflict of interest. The Governor also referred the matter to the President under Article 37 of the Constitution for further action. In a related case, one of Sahukar's daughters has been accused of securing reservation benefits using an allegedly false income certificate and has obtained anticipatory bail.

Confirming the latest development, Vidhana Soudha police inspector SP Kumaraswamy said investigations had begun examining both documentary and digital evidence. "Based on the complaint filed by one Dr Manjunath regarding alleged irregularities in the recruitment of veterinary officers, we have registered an FIR against former KPSC Chairman Shivraj Shankarappa Sahukar and others," he said.

The allegations gained wider attention after an audio clip purportedly showing the former KPSC chairman discussing an Rs 50 lakh payment to secure a veterinary officer post surfaced on social media.

The complaint has also alleged that confidential candi-

date information and OMR related data were unlawfully accessed and shared with middlemen.

Police have invoked provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Samhita relating to cheating which will be taken into account during public examinations at. Investigators are expected to scrutinise digital records, evaluation data, OMR answer sheets and other evidence as part of the inquiry.

Karnataka home minister Priyank Kharge said the investigation would probe the role of job aspirants and called for stronger safeguards governing public recruitment. "Nobody should play with the future of the state and job aspirants. Recruitment to public service must be completely transparent and credible. Let us rise above politics and work together to introduce stronger laws that ensure fairness in recruitment," Kharge said.

He also questioned the circumstances surrounding the former KPSC chairman's appointment and the support he had received during earlier legal proceedings. Police officials said notices would be issued to those named in the FIR.

Pradhan's decision to resign was forced, not out of conscience, doesn't resolve issue: Min

Press Trust of India
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BENGALURU: Karnataka home minister Priyank Kharge on Sunday claimed that Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation was "forced" and said it did not resolve the underlying issues.

"As I said, the resignation was not one of conscience or responsibility. It was forced because it was denting the image of the government, hurting Narendra Modi's popularity, and the Gen Z and students were not ready to relent," Kharge said.

He said the Prime Minister should address Parliament and explain what had happened, how it had happened, and outline the government's blueprint for education reforms.

Kharge also said the Prime Minister should state who ordered the lathi charge, pellet firing and tear gas against the protesting students.



Priyank Kharge

"Just because Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, that doesn't mean the problem is solved," he said. Earlier, Priyank Kharge, on Saturday, launched a scathing attack at the centre, saying that the youth was demonised, accused of receiving foreign funding, and infamously referred to as "cockroaches" who should be sprayed with insecticide.

Addressing a press conference, Kharge said the central government has finally woken up from a "deep slum-

ber" three months after the irregularities came to light.

He further noted that protesting students were accused of spreading food waste and were even subjected to "cockroach" remarks before the government held talks with the Cockerroach Janata Party (CJP).

He also criticised Dharmendra Pradhan for writing a "four-page love letter", stating that his resignation comes to ensure that the anti-national forces do not unite. Meanwhile, JD(S) leader H D Kumaraswamy on Sunday said Pradhan's resignation as Union Education Minister reflects the NDA government's unwavering commitment to the aspirations of students and its resolve to ensure that every genuine concern receives due attention.

Assuring that the government is taking every necessary step to strengthen the examination system, the Union minister urged heavy industries and steel

also urged the students to remain focused on their studies and pursue their dreams with confidence.

Pradhan resigned from his post on Saturday over the alleged NETET paper leak row, saying it is not a matter of "individual prestige" for him.

The protesters' main demand was that Pradhan should step down or be removed from the post. "Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the voice of India's youth has always been heard with sincerity and respect," Kumaraswamy posted on X. "The decision of Pradhan to step down reflects our government's unwavering commitment to the aspirations of students and its resolve to ensure that every genuine concern receives due attention," he said.

Kumaraswamy further said that the Government is taking every necessary step to strengthen the examination system.

Oppn to corner govt over drought in next House session: BJP chief

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BENGALURU: Karnataka BJP President B V Vijayendra on Sunday said that both his party and its alliance partner JD(S) would jointly raise all major issues concerning the state, including drought, during the upcoming legislature session and will hold the Congress government accountable.

His announcement came after chief minister DK Shivakumar earlier in the day said that the monsoon session of the state legislature will begin from August 13.

"Not only discussing, we will also have to find solutions to several key issues concerning the state. We will call a meeting of all our MLAs and MLCs. I will discuss this with R Ashoka, the Leader of Opposition in the Assembly, in this regard," Vijayendra said in response to a question on legislature session.

Speaking to reporters here, he said the BJP and JD(S) together will make the ruling Congress during the session.

"Several issues need to be discussed, like the proposed airport near Kanakapura, drought situation in the state, among others," he added.

Responding to a question regarding the proposed padayatra (march) from Mandya to Bengaluru in protest against the

acquisition of farmers' land for the Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township (GBIT), Vijayendra said he is yet to discuss the matter with the JD(S) leadership.

The discussion could not happen following the demise of party patriarch and former Prime Minister H D Deve Gowda's wife Chennamma. "After discussion, we will decide on it," he added.

Stating that the Congress party and certain organisations were trying to project Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as Union Education Minister as their victory, the BJP chief said, the truth is that, Pradhan resigned as certain vested interests attempted to create unrest in the country by politicising the NEET paper leak issue.

"With the intention that no such attempts should be allowed to succeed and that the matter must be investigated in a fair and transparent manner, Pradhan has resigned," he added. Pradhan resigned as

Union Education Minister on Saturday following weeks of BJP-led nationwide protests over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination and the government's handling of the issue.

The movement, spearheaded by BJP, had consistently demanded Pradhan's resignation and sweeping reforms in the examination system. Welcoming the Education portfolio at the Centre being assigned to senior party leader from Karnataka, Pralhad Joshi following Pradhan's resignation, Vijayendra described it as a matter of pride for the state.

Joshi was administrative experience, including his tenure handling Parliamentary Affairs and other important ministries, would help strengthen India's higher education system," he said, and expressed confidence that under Joshi's leadership, meaningful reforms would be implemented, benefiting both the country and Karnataka.

Alleging that the ruling Congress has a long history of protecting corrupt elements and has failed to deliver on its promises despite publishing its guarantee schemes, Vijayendra said there has been virtually no developmental work in the union head of every family) have failed to meet public expectations despite repeated assurances of improvement.

ONE BOOKED OVER POSTERS BACKING UMAR KHALID AT B'LURU PROTEST

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BENGALURU: Police have registered an FIR against an unidentified woman for allegedly displaying placards carrying slogans in support of jailed activists Umar Farooq Sheikh and Umar Khalid Zindabad, who are facing charges in the 2020 Delhi riots case, during a student protest at Freedom Park. During the review, it was found that an unidentified young woman had deliberately displayed provocative placards with the intention of inciting protest and disturbing public peace," the complaint said.

The officer alleged that she noticed a young woman holding placards bearing the slogans "Umar Khalid Zindabad", "Sharjeel Imam Zindabad" and "Ukhaid Le BLR Police".

The complaint was lodged by a police sub-inspector deployed on bandobast duty, the incident took place between 5 pm and 5.30 pm on Friday while a large gathering of protesters was raising slogans. The officer alleged that she noticed a young woman holding placards bearing the slogans "Umar Khalid Zindabad", "Sharjeel Imam Zindabad" and "Ukhaid Le BLR Police".

{ OVER MEKEDATU DAM }

Farmers bodiesurge Vijay to reject DMKS' invitation to B'luru

Press Trust of India

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THANJAVUR: Representatives of several farmers' organisations in Tamil Nadu on Sunday strongly urged Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to reject Karnataka's invitation for bilateral talks regarding their proposal for constructing a dam across the Cauvery in Mekedatu and other river water issues.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu agriculture minister Vinodh Kumar backed from his earlier statement regarding CM Vijay's trip to Bengaluru, urging reporters to wait the official announcement.

Earlier, he had said chief minister Vijay will be visiting Bengaluru on August 3.

Addressing a district officers' meeting of a farmers' coordination committee in Mayiladuthurai, farmers leader P R Pandian said: "Tamil Nadu Chief Minister must reject the Karnataka Chief Minister's invitation. According to farmers, direct talks could provoke unrest. In the past, when such talks were called, special armed forces were sent to quell the protests, Pandian added.

He insisted that all water-sharing discussions must be strictly channelled through the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA).



Tamil Nadu CM Joseph Vijay chairs a review meeting on the schemes of the agriculture department. @GOTAMILNADU

"The Tamil Nadu chief minister going to Karnataka to talk about Karnataka's plan for a dam in Mekedatu and water release is legally invalid. It is invalid as per the Supreme Court order. It is invalid as per the Constitution," Pandian added.

Highlighting the 2013 Supreme Court directives and the subsequent establishment of the CWMA, he added, "Since the Authority is functioning under the direct supervision of the State Chief Minister, there is no use in any state chief minister meeting to talk. The leaders expressed concern over reports that Tamil Nadu

vehicles were being stopped at the Hengalur-Bengaluru border, alleging that it was a deliberate attempt to provoke linguistic tensions.

Speaking to reporters in Thanjavur, Minister Vinodh Kumar briefly addressed media queries regarding the chief minister's proposed visit to Karnataka. When asked by reporters about conflicting information regarding the trip, the minister clarified, "Official announcements will come from the head office."

The minister was in Thanjavur to inaugurate an initiative to desilt 6 km-long drainage canals with the support of Corporate Social

TN AGRICULTURE MINISTER VINODH KUMAR BACKTRACKED FROM HIS EARLIER STATEMENT REGARDING VIJAY'S BENGALURU TRIP, URGING TO WAIT THE OFFICIAL ANNOUNCEMENT

Responsibility (CSR) funds at an estimated cost of Rs 70 lakh and another drive to remove water hyacinth from water bodies.

Tamil Nadu Minister R Nirmal Kumar also briefly touched upon the Cauvery River water dispute, saying political leaders should understand the facts surrounding inter-state issues before making public statements.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has proposed bilateral talks with his Karnataka counterpart to find an amicable solution to the long-standing Cauvery water-sharing dispute. He is scheduled to visit Bengaluru on August 3 for talks with Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, having sought an appointment that the latter has agreed to.

Meanwhile, senior AIADMK leader RB Udhayakumar

launched a scathing attack on chief minister Vijay on Sunday over his administration's handling of the NEET and the Cauvery water dispute, while also questioning his silence on critical state issues.

"What is the Tamil Nadu government's stance when all of India is burning? Students are asking why the chief minister is not opening his mouth. He remains silent in answering the students protesting on the ground," Udhayakumar said.

On the Cauvery water dispute, Udhayakumar pointed out that despite 53 meetings of the Cauvery Water Management Authority and the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee, Tamil Nadu has failed to secure its rightful share of water.

Udhayakumar questioned what outcome CM Vijay would achieve through talks with Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, noting that nearly 90 per cent of reservoirs remain dry, putting thousands of agricultural areas at risk of drought.

Chief minister Vijay has proposed bilateral talks with his Karnataka counterpart DK Shivakumar in order to seek an amicable solution to the long-standing Cauvery river water-sharing dispute.

'Aadi' festival



People perform rituals during a religious procession marking the 'Aadi' festival, on the outskirts of Chennai on Sunday.

Deep depression in AP may turn into cyclonic storm in 24 hrs: SDMA

Press Trust of India

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AMARAVATI: The APSDMA on Sunday said a deep depression over the northwest Bay of Bengal and adjoining north Odisha-West Bengal coasts was likely to intensify into a cyclonic storm within the next 24 hours. It also warned of strong winds of up to 65 kmph along the north Andhra coast and advised fishermen not to venture into the sea until Wednesday.

According to Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority, the weather system is moving northwards and is expected to cross the north Odisha-West Bengal coast between Paradip and Sagor Island by Monday morning or afternoon.

The deep depression is likely to intensify into a cyclonic storm within the next 24 hours. Boats measuring less than seven metres in length are unsafe for operation, and fishermen should not venture into the sea until Wednesday," APSDMA Managing Director Prakash Jain said in

THE APSDMA ADVISED PEOPLE LIVING IN COASTAL AREAS TO REMAIN ALERT AND FOLLOW OFFICIAL ADVISORIES

a press release. He said the sea was expected to remain rough with high waves, while strong winds of up to 65 kmph were likely along the north Andhra coast over the next 24 hours. He urged coastal residents and fishermen to take necessary precautions.

Under the influence of the weather system, light to moderate rainfall is likely at isolated places in Srikakulam, Vizianagaram, Paravuram, Paluram, Alluri Sitharama Raju, Eluru, Visakhapatnam and Konaseema districts on Monday.

The APSDMA advised people living in coastal areas to remain alert and follow official advisories.

TWO INTERSTATE DRUG TRAFFICKERS HELD IN KERALA

MALAPPURAM: Police on Sunday arrested two alleged interstate drug traffickers and seized nearly 100 grams of MDMA from their possession at Vazhikadavu in this district, officials said.

The arrested men were identified as Saifudheen (38), a native of Manipal, and Riyas Ali (32), a resident of Krumbalanagode, both in Malappuram district. According to the police, the District Anti-Narcotics Special Action Force received information that the duo was travelling from Bengaluru with a large quantity of narcotic drugs.

Acting on the tip-off, the DAN-SAF team intercepted their car near Anamangal Vazhikadavu at around 1 am on Sunday.

Police said an initial search of the vehicle did not yield any contraband. However, a subsequent body search led to the recovery of a packet containing MDMA from the accused.

A total of 98.2 grams of MDMA, estimated to be worth around Rs 8 lakh in the illegal market, was seized, police said.

Vazhikadavu police registered a case under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act and formally arrested the two. A probe is underway. **PI**

{ LOK SABHA, ASSEMBLY ELECTIONS }

T'gana to pass resolution to lower poll contest age

Press Trust of India

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana government will soon convene a special assembly session to pass a resolution urging the Centre to lower the minimum age for contesting the Lok Sabha and Assembly elections to 21 years, Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy has said.

The existing age to contest elections is 25 years. Addressing a candle light rally organised in Hyderabad on Saturday over the NEET paper leak issue, the CM claimed that the Gen Z agitation defeated the "56-inch chest" (a reference to Prime Minister Narendra Modi) and forced Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to step down from his post.

"We will hold a special session of the assembly and legislative council in the first week of August. We will discuss in the assembly and pass a resolution to make 21 years the minimum age to contest as an MLA and MP and send it to the Prime Minister," he said.

Noting that Gen Z representa-



Revanth Reddy

"I will speak to INDIA bloc and meet leaders of every party. These people should not just return home after raising their voice on the streets. These youth should go to Parliament and make the voice of Gen Z heard all over the world," he said.

Reddy noted that 21-year-olds are eligible to become IAS and IPS officers as well as Mayors and Zilla Parishad Chairmen. Recalling earlier reforms, he said former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi lowered the minimum age for voting from 21 to 18, while former PM P V Narasimha Rao enabled 21-year-old youth to contest elections for the post of Congress and Zilla Parishad Chairmen.

The CM further said Congress under the leadership of Rahul Gandhi and AIKC president Mallikarjun Kharge, would raise in Parliament withdrawal of cases registered against students and youth during the NEET stir besides seeking ex-gratia to those who died by suicide following the paper leak.

Deputy CM Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, several ministers, CPI leaders, and large number of youth participated in the march.



Restoration work underway after a private bus overturned near Kuttipuram in Kerala's Malappuram on Sunday. ANI VIDEO GRAB

1 dead, 26 injured in Kerala bus accident

Press Trust of India

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MALAPPURAM: A private bus on the Kozhikode-Thiruvananthapuram highway near Kuttipuram in Kerala's Malappuram district on Sunday morning, killing one person and injuring 26 others, police said.

Following the incident, state transport minister PJ John said that, besides the police investigation, the transport commissioner would conduct a separate inquiry into the accident and submit a report on its cause.

Only after receiving the report will we be able to ascertain whether overspeeding or road construction was the reason for the accident," he said. The minister said it had been decided to conduct such post-crash inquiries following a series of recent accidents.

He said three of the injured were still undergoing treatment in the hospital and were in stable condition.

John condoled the death of Vaisnavi, a resident of Kozhikode.

Visuals from the accident site showed the bus lying upside down, almost bent in the middle, on top of a concrete roadside barrier, with its undercarriage ripped off.

Television footage showed part of the bus resting on a car on the other side of the barrier. A video of the accident showed the bus, apparently travelling at high speed, suddenly veering to the left, hitting the concrete barrier along the service road and overturning.

Police and residents said the stretch was accident-prone. The exact cause of the accident is yet to be ascertained, police said.

A senior police officer said the bus was suspected of having been speeding and that the rain could also have contributed to the accident.

Vijay's 'last film' Jana Nayagan collects over ₹170 cr in 3 days

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Despite facing several hurdles including the movie getting leaked online ahead of its formal release, Jana Nayagan, the latest film of Tamil Nadu chief minister C. Joseph Vijay, has generated over ₹170 crore revenue globally, within 3 days of its release, with film critics attributing it to the emotion attached to the superstar.

After facing legal hurdles in receiving cinema certificates and negativity around the movie, the political action thriller, H Vinodh's directorial, Jana Nayagan formally released on July 23 globally. In Tamil Nadu alone more than 1,000 theatres released the movie.

According to film industry trade experts and industry insiders, the film has collected a revenue of over ₹170 crore within three days of its release and is on course to become a commercial blockbuster.

Noted film producer and twosome National Film award win-



'Jana Nayagan' was released globally on July 23.

ner C Dhananjayan said, "Even though they have now become party cadres, they are still out there to watch Vijay Sir because it is his last film. There are lot of emotions attached to the film and let us remember that."

Underlining that the emotion attached to the film is very big, he said, "This is the film that suffered delay from censors and faced various other issues. It got leaked online also and there was a lot of negativity around it."

Dhananjayan added that the movie has been received well in Kerala and Karnataka markets because everywhere Vijay's fans are present.

2 dead, 1 injured in explosion at firecracker factory in TN

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

SIVAKASI: Two people were killed and one critically injured in a massive explosion at a clandestine firecracker manufacturing unit operating out of an agricultural shed near Sengamallur in Tiruvudhurai district on Sunday morning, police said.

One of the deceased has been identified as 38-year-old Ramprakash and the other is yet to be identified, they said. Ramprakash's brother, Ruma-chandran (40), sustained 60 per cent burn injuries and has been admitted to a nearby hospital for treatment.

According to a senior police official, the brothers had been manufacturing the firecrackers



Dark flames and smoke billow after an explosion at a clandestine firecracker manufacturing unit in Sivakasi on Sunday.

illegally to avoid detection by authorities.

They were running it clandestinely, mostly operating late at night in a shed located in

an agricultural field. The structure was otherwise used to store agricultural tools and, at times, crop yields," the senior police official said.

TN DGP transfers pregnant woman's death case to CB-CID

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SIVAKASI: Tamil Nadu director general of police (DGP) Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal has ordered the transfer of a pregnant woman death case registered in Sivagangai district to the CB-CID for investigation, complying with a directive from the Madras High Court.

The case, originally registered by the Tirupathur Town Police Station, under Section 194 (3) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNS), was formally reassigned on July 25, according to a press note issued on Sunday.

The action follows an order passed by the Madras Bench of the Madras High Court on July 24.

The case stems from the suspicious death of Afrin, a 24-year-old pregnant woman from Tirupathur, who died in June, less than five months after her marriage.

Following allegations by her mother of dowry harassment and foul play — alongside claims of severe procedural violations during the initial autopsy — the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court intervened, ordering a fresh autopsy to be conducted by a Neutral Medical Board and directing the transfer of the investigation to a CB-CID Special Investigation Team (SIT).

In accordance with the judicial directive, the director general of police Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal and Head of the Police Force issued the official order transferring the probe into the death of the woman to premier investigation agency on July 25.

Rahul Gandhi to visit Tamil Nadu on August 1

CHENNAI: Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, is scheduled to visit Tamil Nadu on August 1. TNCC chief B Manickam Tagore said on Sunday.

The visit gains significance as this comes after the party taken part in the TVK-led government's cabinet. Although the exact itinerary has not yet been disclosed, the visit is being closely watched since the timing coincides with the protests against the NEET gaining traction in the state, despite Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigning after the protest over the NEET paper leak.

8 officials shunted for temple donation mishandling in TN

COMBATOR: Eight officials and staff members of the Arulmigu Koniamman Temple in Tamil Nadu's Coimbatore were suspended on Sunday over the misappropriation of funds.

The suspensions, ordered by Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) Minister Ramesh, include four employees directly involved in the collection of the theft and four supervising officials, who were penalised for severe administrative negligence. The disciplinary action follows a probe into the mishandling of donations during the temple's scheduled counting process on July 15. The suspensions came a day after the Ukadam police arrested four temple employees on July 25 for their alleged execution of the theft.

2 Delhi men held in Kerala over minister berth offer fraud

COMBATOR: Eight officials and staff members of the Arulmigu Koniamman Temple in Tamil Nadu's Coimbatore were suspended on Sunday over the misappropriation of funds.

The two accused, Nithin and Gaurav, were taken to Kozhikode from New Delhi on a transit train on Sunday morning, an officer of the Kozhikode cyber police station said. The probe revealed that the main accused, Gaurav, was allegedly involved in similar cases registered in other states, the officer said. They were arrested following a complaint by M L K Vijaya Balakrishnan, who alleged that a person posing as private secretary to MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra called and offered her a ministerial berth for ₹3 crore, police said.

YOUTH STABBED TO DEATH, FRIEND INJURED AFTER ROAD RAGE CLASH

Press Trust of India

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PALAKKAD: A 24-year-old man was killed and his friend seriously injured after they were allegedly stabbed by two persons following a clash over blocking the road at Kozhijampara here, police said on Sunday.

The deceased was identified as Muhammad Shafeek (24), a native of Vadakanchery. His friend, Samson (18), also from Kozhijampara, is undergoing treatment for serious injuries.

Police said the accused, identified as Nelson and Jensen, both natives of Kozhijampara, are absconding and a search has been launched to trace them.

According to the police, the accused were travelling on a bullock cart when Shafeek and his three friends attempted to overtake it on a motorcycle at around 10.30 pm on Saturday near a plywood factory in Kozhijampara.

Despite repeated honking, the bullock cart allegedly did not make way, leading to an altercation between the two groups. During the clash, Nelson allegedly stabbed Shafeek and Samson with a knife, police said.

The injured were initially taken to a nearby hospital and later shifted to a specialty hospital, where Shafeek succumbed to injuries.

Kozhijampara police have registered a case of murder and launched an investigation.

India steadily moving towards self-reliance in defence: Modi

Sanjay Maurya
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday highlighted the achievements of Indian students in international science Olympiads, and community-led environmental conservation efforts, urging citizens to support indigenous products, plant trees and participate in the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign ahead of Independence Day.

In the 196th episode of his monthly radio programme Mann Ki Baat, aired on Kargil Vijay Diwas, Modi began by paying tribute to soldiers who fought in the 1999 Kargil War and said the country was not only honouring their sacrifices but also strengthening its military capabilities through indigenous technology.

Referring to the induction of INS Mahendragiri into the Indian Navy, successful tests of the Pinaka long-range guided rocket and the Kumbha missile system by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), Modi said India was home to ministerial-level science Olympiads in defence. "Whether it is defence production, defence exports or cooperation with friendly nations, India is continuously scaling new heights," he said, adding that agreements related to BrahMos and Astra

{ NARENDRA MODI } PRIME MINISTER

I am immensely proud of the nation's youth power. It is heartening to see the culture of Olympiads and Hackathons steadily growing in India



missiles signed during his recent visit to Indonesia reflected growing global confidence in Indian defence technology.

Turning to education and science, the PM congratulated Indian students for their performance at international Olympiads, calling it a matter of national pride.

Referring to the four International Olympiads held this month—in Paris (Physics), Dubai (Chemistry), Queson City, the Philippines (Biology) and Shanghai (Mathematics)—Modi noted that India topped the Physics Olympiad with all five participants winning gold medals, achieved its best-ever performance in Chemistry with all students securing gold, won medals

for all participants in Biology including one gold, and bagged two gold and four silver medals in Mathematics.

"I am proud of the nation's youth power. It is heartening to see the culture of Olympiads and Hackathons steadily growing in India," Modi said, expressing confidence that more students would participate in such competitions. The PM also hailed the successful launch of Vikram-I, India's first privately developed rocket in severe pain and is likely to lose an eye after being hit by pellet guns. The Union government, as of the time of Gandhi's press conference, had not issued a detailed response to the allegations.

Gandhi posed two direct questions to Shah in the letter. "As Home Minister, did you approve the use of lethal force including pellet guns against students? If not, who did?" he asked. He also sought clarity on the identity of men in plain clothes seen beating students with lathis, asking whether they were police personnel or volunteers, who authorised their deployment.

"Peaceful protest is crucial to any democracy. It is the government's responsibility to protect protesters and resolve their grievances through dialogue," Gandhi wrote, adding that the violence "destroys every norm" and has "outraged the country,"

Youth should promote our border villages: PM

HT Correspondent
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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged youngsters to become ambassadors for India's border villages, asking them to share their experiences with others to promote local tourism and culture, and encourage more youth to visit these remote regions.

Interacting with participants of the Viksit Vibrant Village (VVV) Programme 2026 via video conferencing, the Prime Minister said exposing young people to life in border villages would strengthen national integration while accelerating development in these areas.

Calling the programme a "journey of unity through participation," Modi said the more India's youth understood border villages, the better they would understand the country itself. "The experiences you have gathered cannot be learned in a standard classroom. Share what you have experienced with other young people and inspire them to visit our border villages in large numbers," Modi said.

He added that increased foot-

fall would help improve infrastructure and public services in these villages. "The more youth who visit and stay there, the more they will see and understand the country; and as people begin to visit these villages, amenities and facilities will reach them much faster," he said. Modi said the government was actively promoting tourism in border villages and urged participants to contribute to these efforts by documenting and sharing their experiences.

"I urge every one of you to share your experiences with at least 100 other young people. Stay connected with the people from the regions you visited. If you took photographs or made videos there, share them widely on social media," he said.

Describing young people as central to India's development journey, the PM said they would play a defining role in building a developed nation. "Today's youth are both the driving force behind Viksit Bharat and its greatest beneficiaries. When the power of the youth directly engages with the nation's challenges and solutions, the future will undoubtedly be bright," he said.

'Politics corrupt, won't contest polls any more'

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Former Karnataka chief minister and veteran Congress leader Siddaramaiah announced on Sunday that he will not contest any elections in future, including the 2028 state assembly polls, citing advancing age, declining health and politics becoming "corrupted".

The 79-year-old Congress Working Committee (CWC) member, however, asserted he will remain active in politics and continue speaking on issues affecting the public. "Since the political field has become corrupted today, I will not contest in the 2028 assembly elections. However, remaining active in politics, I will continue to stand as a voice for the people's hardships and joys," Siddaramaiah said in a post in Kannada on X, detailing what he had said at a private event in Mandya district the previous day.

Stressing that the people of the Varuna constituency in Mysuru are urging him to contest the elections once again, he said, "I have decided that I should not contest in any elections henceforth. In the past, when I con-



Siddaramaiah

tested elections, it was the people of the constituency who supported us financially and ensured our victory. But today, such a situation no longer exists." He added: "I am now 79 years old. Our (Congress) government's term has another year and a half remaining. By then, I will be 82 years old. My health is not as robust as it used to be, is no longer possible to work with the same enthusiasm as before."

Siddaramaiah, the longest-serving Karnataka chief minister resigned on May 28, following instructions from the Congress high command, paving the way for DK Shivumakar to take over as CM. The Congress veteran said he will have completed 50 years in public life by the 2028

assembly polls. "I began my political career in 1978 as a Taluk Board member. I have seen both victory and defeat, but I have the satisfaction of never acting against the principles I believed in or betraying my conscience," he said.

Siddaramaiah said money had become central to contesting elections, leaving little space for "honest" politics. "The time has come where, if we contest elections, we would have to give money to the people. Politics today is thoroughly corrupted. Honest politics seems to have no legs to stand on. In this backdrop, I have arrived at the decision not to contest in future elections," he said. He added that his withdrawal from electoral politics would not mark the end of his public life. "For five decades, the people of the state have seen me as one among them and affectionately guided me. This debt I intend to repay by dedicating my future life too will be dedicated to public service," he said.

Before the 2023 assembly polls, Siddaramaiah had intended to seek re-election, but added he would continue to remain in politics thereafter.

Rahul asks Shah if he approved use of 'lethal force' on students

Himanshi Sharma
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NEW DELHI: Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi has written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah demanding accountability for the "barbaric assault" on peaceful protesters in Delhi on July 20, 2026, whether he approved the use of "indiscriminate force" including lethal weapons and tear gas, allegedly leaving hundreds injured.

Gandhi's letter sent on Saturday, came on the day when Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as the Union education minister after due mounting pressure following weeks of nationwide protests over the NEET examination leak fiasco.

"We hold Amit Shah directly responsible for the violence that has taken place against our students. He authorised the shooting of our students. He authorised the use of lethal weapons, including pellet guns, against our students. For us, this is a fundamental right," Gandhi said.

The protests, led by the online collective Cockerhock



Rahul Gandhi

Janta Party (CJP) and backed by activist Sonam Wangchuk, who undertook a 26-day hunger strike at Jantar Mantar, culminated in a "Sanskad Chalo" march from the protest site towards Parliament on July 20. The demonstrators were demanding a fair and accountable education system amid allegations of paper leaks. Police used lethal charges and tear gas shells to disperse the crowd. Pradhan's resignation, submitted to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, came with the minister stating he wanted to ensure the process were not "exploited by anti-national forces."

In his letter, Gandhi said women students "have been

assaulted by policemen, including by deliberately targeting their private parts," and cited the case of 19-year-old student Sahil Lochab, whom he met personally. Gandhi said Lochab was in severe pain and is likely to lose an eye after being hit by pellet guns. The Union government, as of the time of Gandhi's press conference, had not issued a detailed response to the allegations.

Gandhi posed two direct questions to Shah in the letter. "As Home Minister, did you approve the use of lethal force including pellet guns against students? If not, who did?" he asked. He also sought clarity on the identity of men in plain clothes seen beating students with lathis, asking whether they were police personnel or volunteers, who authorised their deployment.

"Peaceful protest is crucial to any democracy. It is the government's responsibility to protect protesters and resolve their grievances through dialogue," Gandhi wrote, adding that the violence "destroys every norm" and has "outraged the country,"

'It's just the beginning, CJP has long way to go'

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NEW DELHI: A day after the Cockerhock Janta Party (CJP) dissolved its 37-day protest at Jantar Mantar over former minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, founder Abhijeet Dipke said it was just the beginning and the party had a long way to go.

Dipke, who's suffering from typhoid and undergoing treatment, issued a video statement on Sunday.

He said, "I want to thank those who criticised and doubted us, and said that we were not serious and did not know how to protest. Had they not questioned or criticised us, we wouldn't have improved. We progressed because of legitimate criticism."

"I have been reiterating since day one, that this is just the beginning, and the CJP has a long way to go, which it will," Dipke added.

He also thanked all CJP supporters who assembled in unprecedented numbers across the country to protest the alleged NEET paper leak.



Abhijeet Dipke thanked all CJP supporters across the country for joining the protest.

He said the 37 days of the protest were "really, really difficult" for him and the team, and he thanked them.

I really want to thank all those who supported us and believed in us when everybody was doubting us," Dipke said, while apologising for not being able to meet his supporters on the last day of the protest due to his health.

He said: "I couldn't meet them, or thank them. I had a high fever, with a body temperature of 101 degrees (Fahrenheit). That's why I had to come back home."

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivumakar, along with former CM Siddaramaiah and state Congress president BK Hariprasad, will travel to New Delhi on Monday for a possible meeting with the Congress high command to finalise the list of candidates for the 20 vacant ministries as part of the long-pending cabinet expansion in the southern state.

A meeting of senior party leaders is scheduled for Monday evening, with leaders familiar with the matter saying the much-delayed cabinet expansion could be announced as early as Tuesday or Wednesday. The exercise comes days before Karnataka's legislative assembly convenes for its monsoon session in the first week of August.

Shivumakar, who was sworn in as CM on July 13 minutes on June 3, following Siddaramaiah's resignation on May 28, on Sunday said he had convened a meeting of Union ministers and lawmakers from Karnataka in Delhi to discuss the drought situation and other issues concerning the state.

More than 60 Congress legislators are eyeing those 20 berths. The final list has already been discussed by Shivumakar and Siddaramaiah with Venugopal and



DK Shivumakar

AICC Karnataka in-charge Randeep Singh Surjewala, people familiar with the matter said. The names now await clearance from Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge as part of the cabinet expansion exercise.

"The list is expected to receive its final approval from Rahul Gandhi, while Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge is also expected to participate in the decision. Some changes remain possible because Rahul Gandhi has favoured bringing more new faces into the ministry," a senior Congress leader said, requesting anonymity.

Among those eyeing a cabinet berth are Babashah Patil, Basnagowda Turvalal, PT. Basnagowda, Vishwas Vaidya, BB Chimmankant, K. Harish Gowda, Ravi Shankar, Prakash Kolliwal and Shivangana Baswaraj. More than 60 Congress legislators are eyeing those 20 berths. The final list has already been discussed by Shivumakar and Siddaramaiah with Venugopal and

due to poverty. If we get a chance, we get caught up to do good work," JN Gangesh told reporters.

The negotiations extend beyond ministerial appointments. Congress leaders are also weighing whether to create two additional deputy chief minister posts alongside G. Parameshwara, a move that leaders in the know said was intended to widen representation for Lingayats, Scheduled Tribes and backward classes.

K'taka CM warns officials against exam paper leaks
Meanwhile, Shivumakar has made direct administration responsible for protecting the integrity of examination process, warning deputy commissioners that they will be held accountable for any question paper leak or security lapse. The department comes as the southern state prepares to recruit more than 72,000 government employees with police and civil service examinations over the coming week.

"Addressing a review meeting, the CM ordered direct administrations to ensure complete transparency throughout the recruitment process and tighten oversight at every stage of the examinations." Question papers must be given enhanced security. Every stage, including pre-examination, printing, distribution and conduct of examinations, must be documented. Let the NEET scam remain a lesson for everyone," he said.

Oppn parties failed to win confidence of youngsters: Uddhav

The picture had become a symbol of resistance on social media during NEET protest. A

MUMBAI: Model who stopped COP VAN ALLEGES HARASSMENT

MUMBAI: The 27-year-old woman, who submitted a written complaint to the police on Saturday and would meet a senior cyber cell officer on Monday, seeking registration of a first information report (FIR) against those targeting her via social media.

There has been consistent harassment, bullying, abuse and slut-shaming (since the July 22 incident). Right now it is online, but it can grow into something much larger. I don't want my parents to be affected by this," Yadav told HT. Referencing a first information report (FIR) against those targeting her via social media.

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MUMBAI: Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday said that Opposition parties had failed to win the confidence of the young generation, amid mounting outrage over the paper leak controversy and student protests that led to Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as Union education minister.

In an interview with Saamanta, Thackeray also expressed disappointment over the functioning of the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc, saying, "The INDIA bloc has been blocked as of now."

Referring to Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the online collective Cockerhock Janta Party (CJP), who returned from the US and emerged as a prominent face of the student movement, Thackeray said the response he received from young people underscored the Opposition's inability to connect with the youth over the past 12 years.



Uddhav Thackeray

lost faith in political parties," he said. On efforts to improve coordination among INDIA bloc partners, Thackeray said he had spoken to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and Maharashtra Congress leaders before announcing Sunday's Tiranga Rally.

"We are trying. Something good will come out of this," he said. Calling the Gen Z-led agitation a "new lifeline" for democracy, Thackeray said political parties must stand with the youth. Referring to the protests, he said the Opposition could not remain silent after the movement's success. "This movement is a spark. We need to stand with them. Otherwise, the anti-democratic ruling regime will crush them, and then no one will be able to save us," he said.

Thackeray said his party, founded by Balasaheb Thackeray and once known as a youth-centric organisation, would continue to champion issues concerning young people. "We have always stood by the youth. We will continue to do so," he said.

{ BIHAR BANDH AGITATION } FOR 'INCITING' PROTESTERS

Tej Pratap sent to judicial custody

Avinash Kumar
avinash.kumar@htlive.com

PATNA: Former Bihar minister and Janshakti Janata Dal (JJD) chief Tej Pratap Yadav, son of RJD supreme leader Lalu Prasad, was sent to 14-day judicial custody on Sunday, hours after his arrest for allegedly "inciting" protesters during agitation against the paper leak in Patna, police said.

The Bihar Bandh call was given by Left organisations such as the All India Student Association (AISA). Shortly after his arrest, Patna police produced Yadav before a judicial magistrate, who sent him to 14-day jail. Patna SSP Kartika Sharma said Yadav was arrested on charges of rioting and accused of provoking demonstrators.

"I am with the students and ready to die for their rights," Yadav said at the protest site.

Tejashvi Yadav, Tej Pratap's brother and RJD working president, said, "My big brother has been arrested wrongfully, and booked under false charges."

In response, PDP leader Wahed Patra accused the NC of twisting Mehbooba's statement using force against Kashmiri protesters by saying "banta hai" is nothing short of disgraceful. Worse still, she has gone to the extent of branding protesting Kashmiris as 'militants'. I think she should apologise for such a disgraceful statement," he said.



Tej Pratap Yadav waves Tricolour during a protest in Patna.

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NC spokesperson, Tanvir Sadiq demanded Mufli to apologise for her statements. "For a former CM to virtually justify the

'Not a single paper leak case during AAP tenure'

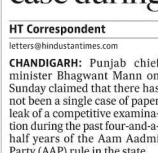
HT Correspondent
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CHANDIGARH: Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday claimed that there has not been a single case of paper leak of a competitive examination during the past four-and-a-half years of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) rule in the state.

The chief minister said this at an event in Zikarpur, where he felicitated 882 students from the state's government-run qualified NEET 2026, describing the achievement as a reflection of the state's education reforms, saying that the number of successful candidates had never been even higher had the examination paper not been leaked.

Mann further launched attack on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led Union government, referring to repeated paper leaks as a "complete failure." He said similar incidents had occurred in 2017, 2024 and again in 2026, leaving many deserving students disappointed.

Referring to the recent pharmaceutical recruitment examination in Faridkot, he said the government acted immediately after receiving information about an attempt to facilitate cheating. He said 24 accused had been arrested and sent to jail in connection with the racket, reiterating that his government will not allow even a single incident of paper leakage or cheating to jeopardise the



Bhagwant Mann

future of Punjab's youth. "We have been in power for the past four-and-a-half years. Not a single paper leak has happened in Punjab." He attributed the milestone to the government's investment in government education, free coaching, mentorship and career counselling under the Punjab Academic Coaching for Excellence (PACE) programme.

According to the state government, 686 of the 882 successful NEET candidates are girls, while 340 belong to the Scheduled Caste community. Over the past three years, 2,166 government school students have qualified NEET and 786 have cleared JEE, reflecting the growing academic performance of Punjab's government schools.



Bhagwant Mann

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'No difference between Indian and Pak military, militaries'

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NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Sunday said Operation Sindoor demonstrated India's ability to retaliate against any Pakistani misadventure with force beyond its imagination, ruling out talks with the neighbouring country on any issue other than Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.

Speaking at 27th Kargil Vijay Divas celebrations in Dras, Singh asserted there was no distinction between military and militants in Pakistan where terrorism is a part of state policy. "Pakistan's military not only shelters terrorist organisations but also works with them. That is why, during Operation Sindoor, we made it clear that India no longer views terrorists and the governments that nurture them as separate entities," Singh said.

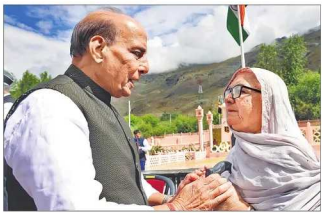
Kargil Vijay Divas celebrations highlight how Indian soldiers overcame daunting odds to drive out a treacherous enemy from the strategic heights it had occupied in the Kargil sector in the summer of 1999. Army chief General Dhiraj Seth also attended the event in Dras to commemorate victory in the limited war—India's first fought along a 170-km mountain frontier, stretching from Mashkhol Valley to Turtuk in the Kargil sector.

Singh said every nefarious act by Pakistan against India's sovereignty would be met with the same resolute response that Indian forces delivered to terrorists and their patrons through Operation Sindoor. The defence minister said 27 years after the Kargil War, the two countries have taken divergent paths, highlighting how the neighbouring country backs terrorists and their activities.

"While India is exploring new avenues of innovation, Pakistan is seeking new routes for infiltration. India is engaged in chip design, whereas Pakistan is busy designing terror. India is building a start-up ecosystem, while Pakistan is building a terror ecosystem. India is manufacturing semiconductors; Pakistan is preparing suicide bombers. India is recognised for space missions, while Pakistan is running proxy missions," Singh said.

India, he added, is sending satellites into space, whereas Pakistan focuses on sending terrorists across the border. "India is providing software to the world, while Pakistan is exporting sleeper cells. India is establishing data centres; Pakistan is setting up radicalisation centres. India is connecting the world through UPI, while Pakistan is linking terrorism with hawala networks."

As many as 527 Indian soldiers were killed during the Kargil war. While there is no definitive account of Pakistani army casualties, different estimates peg the number between a few hundred and a few thousand. A few months after the Lahore peace declaration was



Rajnath Singh interacts with a family member of a fallen soldier during the 27th Kargil Vijay Divas celebrations at Kargil War Memorial in Dras on Sunday.

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{ CABINET SECRETARY TO BUREAUCRATS }

'Stop playing safe, delegate more to juniors'

Sanjeev K Jha

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NEW DELHI: Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan has asked senior bureaucrats to shed the "playing safe" approach and delegate greater authority to junior civil servants, emphasising that excessive centralisation can slow government functioning, overwhelm senior officers and deprive subordinates of the opportunities to develop as decision-makers.

In a communication to all secretaries to the Union government on July 21, Somanathan has made a case for building a "culture of trust" in government departments, saying officers are



TV Somanathan

"often uncomfortable delegating important work because they fear subordinates may not perform as effectively, could misuse their authority, or make decisions that may bring criticism to the government or organisation." But such concerns, he added, should not become an excuse for concerning decision-making at higher levels.

Officers entrusted with authority generally become more responsible, with a person taking a decision independently likely to exercise greater care than one merely recommending a course of action to a superior, Somanathan said in the communication, sent by HT.

The Cabinet secretary also identified reluctance at the end of the administrative chain: officers who have been delegated powers but continue to send matters to their superiors for approval. Such officials, he noted, may have become conditioned to the mindset of "playing safe". The challenge, therefore, lies both with seniors unwilling to delegate and juniors hesitant

to exercise the authority already given to them," he said.

Somanathan invoked the well-known maxim that a ship may be safest in harbour, but that is not where ships are built for. To underline the need for calculated risk-taking in administration. His message is part of a broader Cabinet Secretariat effort to issue practical guides for civil servants, following an earlier communication in June on conducting effective meetings, people pleasing, and other factors.

Judicious delegation, Somanathan said, could be "thrill" and "blessed", improving organisational efficiency, saving scarce time of senior officers and building capabilities of subordinates.

4 killed, 2 injured in Assam factory blast

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SILCHAR: Four people died and at least two were injured after an explosion at a metal processing industry in Assam's Cachar district spilled molten metal on workers on Sunday, police said, even as the families of the victims and local residents alleged that this was not the first such incident, demanding a proper investigation into it.

According to police, the explosion took place around 11 am at Kade Global Infrastructure LLP's metal processing unit at Pangrum under Udhlabond constituency, Kade Global Infrastructure LLP could not be reached for comment.

Local residents rushed to the spot, followed by police, fire and emergency personnel who rescued several injured workers. While some were shifted to hospitals for treatment, others were sent home after treatment for minor injuries. There were over 100 workers in the factory when the explosion took place.

When we reached the spot, we saw that the bodies had been torn apart, with body parts scat-

tered over a wide area," a local resident said. The deceased were identified as Appu Borai (32), Kiron Munda (28), Sivanagar Gaur (30), all residents of Udhlabond and Sagar Nath from Tripura's Agartala. Police said all four died on the spot. After doctors at Silchar Medical College and Hospital confirmed the deaths, the bodies were sent for post-mortem examination, police said. "The bodies have been identified by the family members. A case will be registered and further investigation is underway," Cachar senior superintendent of police (SSP) Sanjay Sankar said.

According to police, Kade Global Infrastructure LLP was established in the area a few years ago and operates two units where scrap metal collected from different sources is processed. Sunday's explosion occurred at the newer unit at Pangrum, which was set up about a year ago. Assam minister Kaushik Rai, who visited the spot, said a magisterial inquiry has been ordered along with a police investigation and a separate probe by the district labour commissioner to ascertain whether mandatory safety measures for workers were followed. "The district administration has sought details from the owners regarding safety measures being followed in the factory. The exact cause of the explosion is also being investigated," Rai said.

He said CM Himanta Biswa Sarma had called him to take stock of the situation and assured that the state government would provide ₹5 lakh each to the families of the deceased. "We will also ask the company owners to provide adequate compensation to the family members," he added.

Meanwhile, locals alleged that similar explosions of lower intensity had taken place at the factory several times in the past but not officially reported.

LOCALS ALLEGED THAT SIMILAR EXPLOSIONS OF LOWER INTENSITY HAD TAKEN PLACE MANY TIMES IN THE PAST BUT WERE NEVER OFFICIALLY REPORTED

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2 DEAD, 1 INJURED IN FIRECRACKER UNIT BLAST IN TN

Press Trust Of India

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SVAKASI: Two people were killed and one critically injured in a massive explosion at a clandestine firecracker manufacturing unit operating out of an agricultural shed near Sengampalappatti in Virudhunagar district on Sunday morning, police said.

One of the deceased has been identified as 38-year-old Ramprakash and the other is yet to be identified, they said. Ramprakash's brother, Ramachandran (40), sustained 60+ burn injuries and has been admitted to a nearby hospital for treatment, police said.

According to a senior police official, the brothers had been practising the firecrackers illegally to avoid detection by authorities. "They were running it clandestinely, mostly operating late in the night in a shed located in an agricultural field. The structure was otherwise used to store agricultural tools and, at times, crop yields," the senior police official told PTI.

The official noted that the operation was kept entirely hidden from the local community.

Virudhunagar district police have registered a case and are conducting further probe to ascertain the identity of the deceased helper and determine the exact cause of the ignition.

{ SAMBALH }

Private double-decker bus overturns, 3 killed

HT Correspondent

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MEERUT: A private double-decker bus travelling from Uttar Pradesh's Bahraich to Punjab overturned in Sambhal district early on Sunday, killing three passengers and injuring more than 25, police said, adding that preliminary enquiries indicate that the driver may have dozed off, causing the vehicle to hit the central divider and overturn.

Police said the accident happened at Chandausi tehsil when the speeding bus first struck the divider and then toppled, trapping passengers and sparking panic on board. The bus was carrying about 150 passengers, several of them migrant workers from Punjab after visiting their hometowns.

Additional superintendent of police (North) Manoj Rawat confirmed the incident, adding that the bus was carrying about 150 passengers and the driver dozed off moments before



The bus was carrying about 150 passengers.

the crash, causing the bus to veer off course.

Chief medical officer Dr. Tarun Pathak had initially reported two fatalities; officials later confirmed the toll had risen to three.

Doctors at the Baijoi Community Health Centre declared Neha (17), daughter of Gangaram of Gajpur in Bahraich, and Pinta (36), son of Lalan Singh of Gonda, dead on arrival. Rishabh Singh (35), son of Shiv Kumar Singh of Shankarpur in Bahraich, succumbed to critical injuries later.

I dead as bus skids on Kerala highway, flips

Press Trust of India

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MALAPPURAM: A private bus on the Kozhikode-Thiruvananthapuram route overturned on the highway near Kuttippuram in this district on Sunday morning, killing one person and injuring 26 others, police said.

Following the incident, state Transport Minister P.C. John said that, besides the police investigation, the transport commissioner would conduct a separate inquiry into the accident and submit a report on its cause.

"Only after receiving the report will we be able to ascertain whether overspeeding or road construction was the reason for the accident," he said.

The minister said it had been decided to conduct such post-mortem inquiries following a series of recent accidents.

He said three of the injured were still undergoing treatment in the hospital and were in stable condition.

John condoned the death of



The private bus overturned on highway near Kuttippuram.

Vaishnav, a native of Kozhikode. Visuals from the accident site showed the bus lying upside down on top of a concrete roadside barrier, with its undercarriage ripped off.

Television footage showed the bus lying upside down on top of a concrete roadside barrier, with its undercarriage ripped off.

A video of the accident showed the bus apparently travelling at high speed before turning over suddenly veering to the left, skidding on the road and hitting the concrete barrier along the service road.

Police and residents said the stretch was accident-prone.

Bengal: Complaint against actor, 2 held over insult to PM

KOLKATA: Two men were arrested on Sunday from Bengal's North and South 24 Parganas districts on charges of insulting Prime Minister Narendra Modi during Friday's student agitation in Kolkata against the NEET question paper leak row, police said.

Meanwhile, BJP leader Keya Ghosh lodged a police complaint against actor Sreelekha Mitra, accusing her of posing with an "objectionable" and "vulgar" cartoon of the PM during Friday's student agitation in Kolkata.

Mitra said, "I merely took the photo from a student and posed with it during the baton charge by the police. I was not wearing my prescription glasses the day I was arrested, so I could not see the photo closely. If I am arrested for this then I am sure another agitation will start," the actor said in a video message.

Arunachal minister dismisses claims of Chinese intrusion

ITANAGAR: Arunachal Pradesh home minister

Mama Natung said on Sunday 24 Parganas districts on charges of insulting Prime Minister Narendra Modi during Friday's student agitation in Kolkata against the NEET question paper leak row, police said.

Meanwhile, BJP leader Keya Ghosh lodged a police complaint against actor Sreelekha Mitra, accusing her of posing with an "objectionable" and "vulgar" cartoon of the PM during Friday's student agitation in Kolkata.

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A CCTV grab of the incident.

DAUGHTER OF DMK LEADER MK ALAGIRI ASSAULTS BANK OFFICIAL, BOOKED

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Kavalvizhi Alagiri, the daughter of former union minister MK Alagiri and the granddaughter of former Tamil Nadu chief minister M Karunanidhi, was booked under multiple sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for allegedly slapping the manager of a public sector bank, police said on Sunday.

According to the police, Kavalvizhi Alagiri was a commercial building in Adyar in the city where the State Bank of India branch is located. The branch manager had complained that the non-unioning of an elevator in the building to a representative of Kavalvizhi Alagiri and since the issue was not resolved, he preferred to escalate the matter to Kavalvizhi herself, police said.

During an argument with the manager Kavalvizhi Alagiri slapped the official and the incident was recorded in the CCTV in manager's office. The clip was widely shared on Sunday.

The bank manager lodged a complaint with the Adyar police, following which Kavalvizhi was booked under the BNS Sections 296 (b) [using obscene words in a public space], 115(2) [causing physical hurt], 351(2) [criminal intimidation] and others, a senior police officer said.

In a social media post, the bank said, "With reference to the unfortunate incident that occurred at one of our branches in Chennai, we reiterate that the safety, dignity and well-being of our employees remain paramount." A DMK spokesperson did not respond to queries for comment.

Excessive mining, weak embankments, wetland loss intensified Assam deluge

Utpal Parashar

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GUWAHATI: Rupak Gogoi, a 38-year-old government school teacher in Assam's Sonari, the headquarters of Charaideo district, and his elderly parents and 33-year-old brother, had barely finished dinner on July 18 when floodwaters rushed into their ground-floor home. It rains heavily in the district, but a flooded home was a first.

As the water level kept rising, the family was forced to move to the floor. Mirza Zulfikar Rahman, which is a big floodplain surrounded by hills. "The Mokoching district in the state received 493% more rain than normal over this period. There was excess rainfall in the two neighbouring Assam districts in Wokha and Morigaon as well as those days," said Sarma.

He said that Charaideo district in Assam also got 436% more rain than normal on those three days. So, the excess volume of water flowing from Nagaland coupled with above average rainfall in the two Assam districts led to many areas in Sibsagar and Charaideo districts getting submerged. The two districts usually don't get flooded," said Sarma.

Sibsagar MLA Akhil Gogoi, who is from the Rajar Dui, on Saturday said that apart from heavy rainfall in Nagaland, other factors like mining along the Assam-Nagaland border areas (both legal and illegal) and removal of stones and sand from river beds in the area also contributed to the deluge. "IMD has clarified that there was no cloud burst in Nagaland that led to flooding in Assam. One factor was the heavy rainfall there. Another was illegal mining which led to the formation of large pits.



People carry household belongings from their flood-submerged home in Nagaon district.

of rain against a normal of 30.3mm (an excess of 181%) between July 18 and 20, led to a sudden rise in water level in the two neighbouring Assam districts in Wokha and Morigaon as well as those days," said Sarma.

He said that Charaideo district in Assam also got 436% more rain than normal on those three days. So, the excess volume of water flowing from Nagaland coupled with above average rainfall in the two Assam districts led to many areas in Sibsagar and Charaideo districts getting submerged. The two districts usually don't get flooded," said Sarma.

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Once these pits flooded, the excess water split over to the Assam side," he said.

Experts believe that while the flooding in the two districts was massive, the incident is part of a pattern seen in several areas of the northeast, particularly in Assam, which is a big floodplain surrounded by hills.

"These kinds of disasters were happening sporadically in different parts of the state. Different places are getting affected at different times, which is now a reality. No one living in Assam can be considered safe from such incidents," said Mirza Zulfikar Rahman, a researcher on the Brahmaputra river basin. The reasons for flooding are weak embankments at places not considered flashpoints for flooding. Excessive mining in Nagaland, degradation of wetlands and large-scale infrastructure development like construction of highways, which are several feet higher than surrounding areas, are other factors," he added.

Rahman said the focus has primarily been on finding quick-fix solutions and handing aid. "Scientific measures to predict such disasters, lessons learnt from past disasters, international cooperation to find solutions and proper coordination between government and other sectors are needed."

26 MISSING FOREST DEPT OFFICIALS RETURN HOME

Biswa Kalyan Purkayastha

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GUWAHATI: Twenty-three Assam forest officials and three accompanying villagers, who had gone missing for two days while on a patrol along the Assam-Nagaland border, were traced on Sunday following a search operation conducted by the department officials said.

The 26-member team had left for a routine patrolling and combing operation on July 23 in the remote forests around Majbung along the Dima Hasao-Karbi Anglong-Nagaland border.

Forest minister Jayanta Malla Baruah, said in a post on X. "The team had lost its way while carrying out patrolling and combing operations in the remote forests along the Dima Hasao-Karbi Anglong-Nagaland border, where network connectivity is limited," Baruah said.

DFO Dima Hasao, Tuhin Langthasa said preliminary findings suggested that the team had lost its way after communication was cut off in the remote forest.

{ GREENPIECE }

STATES SHOULD BEGIN CLIMATE DIPLOMACY

Bharati Chaturvedi

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NEW DELHI: The horrific, ongoing floods in Upper Assam should jolt India awake.

Reports point out the challenges in the neighbouring Nagaland, where forests have been denuded, including for mining. The burden is being borne by Assam. The science is elementary: rainwater cannot percolate into the ground unless its flow is slowed down and the ground can "trap" it. A healthy forest offers this service entirely for free. Unfortunately, Nagaland's extractive policies are causing water to arrive in greater volume, with greater force. That is why these floods are so much worse. This is how the Dikhow river, flowing from Nagaland to Assam, has savaged districts like Sivassagar.

To clarify, there is no doubt about excessive rainfall in both Nagaland and Assam: 493% excess in Nagaland's Mokoching district and 386% in Assam's Charaideo district, according to a statement by Assam's chief minister. This is largely on account of climate change. Shocks like Super Cyclone Idu will inevitably lead to floods once more. The question is how to reduce the impact. Assam should not only think of the inter-state politics for the Brahmaputra watershed, but also begin climate diplomacy with its neighbouring states by encouraging people. Afforestation using local species should be a top priority in mission mode. Early-warning systems and public preparedness should be encouraged. Local people must cooperatively evaluate how they can reduce their own vulnerability as also that of their neighbours. Only with strong interstate cooperation and the country's climate change for every Indian.

(The writer is the founder and director of *Climate Environmental Research and Action Groups*)

Have fun with facts on Sunmays

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HT TWW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



TASK FORCE ON EXAMS

Madras director V Kamakoti, former education secretary Anita Karwal and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

According to people aware of the matter, the multidisciplinary group has been tasked with recommending technological interventions and structural reforms for the NTA, with a particular focus on strengthening the examination system through technology.

Union home minister Amit Shah said the task force reflected the government's commitment to "comprehensive examination reforms" and would ensure that "no one can ever breach the sanctity of our examination system". In a post on X, he also said those responsible for paper leaks would face "exemplary punishment".

The Congress questioned the need for a fresh panel, arguing that the Centre was yet to fully implement the recommendations of the K Radhakrishnan committee, constituted in June 2024 after the NEET-UG controversy that year.

The seven-member committee headed by former IAS chairman K Radhakrishnan submitted its report in October 2024, recommending structural strengthening of the NTA, closer coordination with states, tighter oversight of outsourced vendors and stronger safeguards for both pen-and-paper and computer-based examinations, including encrypted digital transmission of question papers, multi-layer access controls, real-time audit trails and enhanced CCTV surveillance.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh alleged that the government had not implemented all 101 recommendations of the committee and had left the NTA without a full-time director general for much of the period between the 2024 and 2026 examination controversies. In a post on X, he described the new task force as "a high-powered attempt to fix the Pradhan Mantri's irrevocably compromised image."

After Subodh Kumar Singh was removed as NTA director general in June 2024 following the NEET-UG controversy, retired IAS officer Pradeep Singh Kharia was given additional charge of the post until Abhishek Singh took over as the agency's full-time director general on April 1, 2026.

A parliamentary standing committee on education, in a

report tabled in December 2025, found that at least five of the 14 competitive examinations conducted by the NTA in 2024 and early 2025 had faced "major issues".

Government officials, however, said several recommendations of the Radhakrishnan committee had already been implemented. These include creation of 16 additional permanent posts in the NTA, constitution of district-level coordination committees headed by district magistrates for NEET-UG, and shifting examination centres to government or government-owned buildings, with the NTA claiming 94% compliance.

However, many of the reforms remain incomplete. Of the NTA's 39 sanctioned permanent posts, all to be filled on deputation, only 24 are occupied. The agency currently functions with 73 contractual employees and 124 outsourced personnel, despite the committee recommending replacement of contractual staffing with permanent and accountable workforce.

The Centre is also considering introducing an upper age limit and capping the number of attempts for NEET-UG, which currently has no such restrictions. It is also planning a gradual transition to computer-based testing, another recommendation of the Radhakrishnan committee.

The NTA informed the parliamentary panel in May this year that the first phase of reforms, implemented for NEET-UG 2026 and the June 21 re-examination, included Aadhaar-linked biometric verification, facial authentication, multi-layer police frisking, mobile jammers and AI-enabled CCTV surveillance. The second phase under consideration includes cloud-based infrastructure, stronger encryption, an NTA-owned public testing platform and eventual harmonisation of engineering and medical entrance examinations through common standards and processes.

Modi's announcement came a day after Pradhan resigned, becoming the first Union minister in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government's three terms to step down following the student protests. The Centre also accepted key demands raised by the Cockerham Janta Party (CJP), which spearheaded the agitation, including compensation for

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide following examination irregularities and the withdrawal of first information reports registered against protesters, prompting organisers to call off their strike at Jantar Mantar on Saturday.

Union commerce affairs minister Prahallad Joshi, who was given additional charge of the education ministry after Pradhan's resignation, assumed office on Sunday and held his first review meeting with senior officials at Kartavya Bhavan.

Opposition parties are expected to raise the NEET controversy and the proposed anti-paper leak legislation when Parliament resumes on Monday. CJP founder Abhishek Dikpe said the organisation would continue to monitor implementation of the government's assurances and campaign for wider examination reforms. "The protest has ended. The movement has not," he said.

SEAFARERS MISSING

MV Golden Leo had been engaged by Navi Mumbai-based Gurukripa Marine Services Private Limited, Pratinaga Tripathi of Gurukripa Marine Services said DNA tests have identified the bodies of the missing seafarers.

Hours after the attack on MV AON Ragnar, the Centre on Sunday urged Indian seafarers operating on merchant vessels in or transiting the Black Sea to take additional precautions, including ensuring adequate insurance coverage and emergency preparedness.

An advisory issued by the ministry of external affairs said the security situation in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas remains "highly volatile" because of the ongoing conflict.

"Commercial vessels operating in or transiting these waters are facing significant security risks, including missile and drone attacks," the advisory said. There has been an increase in such attacks on commercial vessels since April, resulting in the death of five Indians.

Four Indian seafarers were on MV AGN Ragnar, a Palau-flagged cargo vessel, when it was "struck at the port of Odessa" on Saturday, the Indian embassy in Kyiv said on social media. "As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals," the embassy said.

Search and rescue operations were underway and the embassy was closely monitoring the situation.

The advisory said that Indian nationals intending to work on commercial vessels operating in or transiting the conflict-affected Black Sea region should "carefully assess the prevailing security risks before accepting such assignments".

Seafarers choosing to work in the region should exercise "utmost caution" and take other precautions, including obtaining comprehensive information from employers, recruitment agencies and ship operators regarding the vessel's route, ports of call, security arrangements, insurance coverage, and emergency response procedures, the advisory said.

Last week, the Directorate of Maritime Administration issued an advisory to Indian shipowners and Recruitment and Placement Services Licence (RPSL) agencies to avoid deploying Indian seafarers on vessels operating in the Black Sea and Yemen waters.

The circular on the Black Sea cited a sharp rise in missile and drone attacks on merchant vessels since April 2026.

US, IRAN HALT STRIKES

Sunday. Tehran in recent days has counterattacked against countries in the region holding U.S. military forces, killing at least three at a base in Jordan.

The 60-day period that began when the interim deal was signed by both countries in mid-June is now well into its second half, and major issues that were meant to be negotiated—notably Iran's nuclear program at the heart of tensions—remain set aside as mediators try to keep both sides talking.

A regional official involved in mediation efforts said diplomacy was underway and that a pause in U.S. and Iranian strikes was a "positive signal that helps their efforts to de-escalate."

The official said both countries want to return to the interim ceasefire deal and that a compromise being negotiated centers on having Iran run vessel transit through the Strait of Hormuz with fewer restrictions on ships. The official was not authorized to discuss the matter and spoke on condition of anonymity.

Concerns continued about shipping on the strait and now on another crucial waterway in the region, the Bab al-Mandeb, the embassy said.

backed Houthis rebels in Yemen last week threatened a blockade of Saudi shipping there.

Global energy supplies and the economy remain in the balance as gasoline prices have risen again.

Iran on Sunday said it continued to speak with Oman about managing the safe passage of ships on the Strait of Hormuz, which passes between the countries. Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson, Esmail Baghaei, said talks had made progress and continued.

Baghaei also said the strait's status remained unchanged. Tehran has asserted that the interim deal with the U.S. allows it to manage shipping on the waterway for now, and it has objected to U.S. efforts to support a route through the strait that passes close to Oman instead.

The strait was considered an international waterway before the war.

The U.S. military on Saturday said its recently reimposed naval blockade against Iran continued, with a dozen commercial ships redirected, two disabled and two boarded. U.S. forces "remain highly vigilant, focused, lethal, and ready," it added.

Meanwhile, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu plans to travel to the United States and meet with Trump in Washington on Tuesday, his office has said. They last met in Washington in February, weeks before they launched the war on Iran that killed senior leaders including Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

The Iranian-backed Hezbollah fired at Israel two days after the war began, and Israel responded with airstrikes and ground forces in southern Lebanon. Since then, the U.S. has supported landmark direct talks between Lebanon and Israel to try to calm the front and find a way to disarm Hezbollah.

Netanyahu on Sunday told Fox News he "fully" backs Trump's efforts to weaken Iran and press it to end its nuclear program, adding: "If he can do so without returning to intense military fighting, that's fine. Why not?"

The prime minister indicated he would not present new information to "our good friend" Trump and instead would listen to "what he has in mind, because I think in many ways, it's his decision."

But Netanyahu warned that if Iran again attacked Israel, directly or with armed proxies, "it will make a terrible mistake."

{ OVER MEKEDATU DAM }

Farmer bodies urge Vijay to 'reject' K'taka CM's invite for bilateral talks

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com



C. Joseph Vijay

THANJAVUR: Representatives of several farmers' organisations in Tamil Nadu on Sunday strongly urged Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to reject Karnataka's invitation for bilateral talks regarding their proposal for constructing a dam across the Cauvery in Mekedatu and other river water issues.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu agriculture minister Vinohar Pandian said the government would not accept the invitation for bilateral talks regarding the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA). "The Tamil Nadu chief minister going to Karnataka to talk about Karnataka's plan for a dam in Mekedatu and water release is legally invalid. It is invalid as per the Supreme Court order. It is invalid as per the Constitution," Pandian added.

Highlighting the 2013 Supreme Court directives and the subsequent establishment of the sub-

past, when such talks were called, contradictions arose, clashes have erupted," Pandian added. He insisted that all water-sharing discussions must be strictly channelled through the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA). "The Tamil Nadu chief minister going to Karnataka to talk about Karnataka's plan for a dam in Mekedatu and water release is legally invalid. It is invalid as per the Supreme Court order. It is invalid as per the Constitution," Pandian added.

CWMA, he added. "Since the Authority is functioning under the direct supervision of the Supreme Court, there is no use in any state chief ministers meeting to talk. The leaders expressed concern over reports that Tamil Nadu vehicles were being stopped at the Hosur-Bengaluru border, alleging that it was a deliberate attempt to provoke linguistic sentiments.

Speaking to reporters in Thanjavur, Minister Vinohar Pandian briefly addressed media queries regarding the chief minister's proposed visit to Karnataka. When asked by reporters about conflicting information regarding the trip, the minister clarified, "Official announcements will come from the head office."

The minister was in Thanjavur to inaugurate an initiative to desilt 6 km-long drainage canals with the support of Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) funds at an estimated cost of ₹70 lakh and another drive to remove water hyacinth from water bodies.

Goa CM backs police action over 'Khalid' placards at protests

PANAJI: Goa chief minister Pramod Sawant said on Sunday that those involved in anti-national movements won't be tolerated in the coastal state, even as police questioned the organisers of two protests, where placards demanding the release of Umar Khalid were allegedly displayed.

Police questioned Amreen Shaikh, the head of Utsav NGO, which had called for protests in Mapusa and Panaji on Friday and Saturday, respectively, over NEET paper leak. The Goa police detained two youngsters.

Justifying the police action, Sawant said it was unfortunate that the protest held to demand action in the NEET paper leak was used as a platform to peddle "anti-national agenda by sympathising with Khalid".

Tourist dies in flash flood near waterfall in Thane, 1 missing

THANE: A 21-year-old man died, another remained missing, while three tourists were rescued after they were swept away in a flash flood triggered by heavy rain near a waterfall in Shahapur taluka of Thane district on Sunday, officials said.

The incident occurred at a popular waterfall near Chondhe in Dolkhamb area, where the group of five friends from Kalyan had gathered for a weekend outing.

Following torrential, localised heavy rainfall akin to a cloudburst, water levels in the local stream rose sharply, sweeping five tourists away in the powerful currents, an official said. Three individuals were successfully pulled out to safety during a challenging rescue effort, the official added.

REALITY OF LIVE-IN RELATIONS CAN BE SEEN ACROSS THE WORLD: BHAGWAT

HYDERABAD: RSS Chief Mohan Bhagwat on Sunday said marriage is a discipline which instils dharm, while the reality of live-in relationships can be seen all over the world.

Speaking at an event on 'contemporary motherhood' organised by Vishwa Mangalya Sabha here, he also said Gen Z is imitative, emotional and does not think with a calm mind, and what comes across to them as genuine appeals.

"Marriage is a discipline which instils dharm. Its alternative is live-in relationship. Modernity. What are its consequences? We don't want responsibilities but happiness. Stay together when it is wanted and part ways when not wanted. No responsibilities. What will grow with it? What is growing, look around the world," he said.

He, however, said modernity is also needed and changing with times is also a rule in the country's traditions.

Hindustan Times

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{ OUR TAKE }

A test for the testing agency

Efforts to restructure NTA show that the Centre has belatedly recognised that testing is a specialised process requiring specialised skills

The wholesale sacking of people at the National Testing Agency (NTA), the announcement of the creation of four senior specialised positions — covering testing, test network management, cybersecurity, and vigilance — and the creation of a high-powered task force headed by Nandan Nilekani is, for starters, admission that the organisation expected to conduct many kinds of college admission tests isn't equipped to do so. It is also an indication that things are now moving in the right direction — although much will depend on the kind of people the agency is able to attract for the positions it hopes to fill.

That the Union government decided to centralise testing without having the ability to do so, and in the face of opposition from some states, makes this a political issue — which will be raised time and again — but the purge at the agency, and the resignation of the Union education minister should satisfy those keen on punitive action.

The more important aspect is remedial action, and while it may have done so under duress, the government's efforts to restructure NTA show that it has belatedly recognised that testing — all aspects of it — is a specialised process requiring specialised skills. At its very core, a test of the kind NTA conducts — the undergraduate edition of the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test, for instance, for admission to medical colleges — should be a fair, and statistically sound assessment of an individual's abilities. Given the scale of the tests conducted by NTA — a few million students appear for it every year — logistics and security (including cybersecurity) present an additional layer of complexity. The changes announced on Friday go some way towards addressing these; and the composition of the task force, some more.

Where the government is silent on is the issue of governance. It may be a good idea to benchmark NTA's current governance norms against those of similar bodies around the world — including the US College Board, a non-profit that is not owned by the State, but governed by members, basically educational institutions. Members elect trustees, and the board of trustees appoints the CEO and the executive team, which runs several kinds of tests, offering them many times a year. In India, where many educational institutions are run by the Centre or states, a pragmatic solution may be a Goods and Services Tax Council kind of body with representation from states, and also from private universities.

Beijing's sovereignty claims erode trust

India's recent assertion that China continues to illegally occupy vast tracts of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir highlights the shadow of the dragging border dispute on the ongoing process of normalising and rebuilding bilateral relations. The external affairs ministry's response to the Chinese foreign ministry's, yet another, attempt to drag such issues into its official statements on recent bilateral meetings involving external affairs minister S Jaishankar and national security adviser Ajit Doval. The Chinese side earlier imputed that India has endorsed China's position on Tibet, Taiwan, and sovereignty-related matters. The external affairs ministry immediately clarified that it is the Indian side, not China, which should be raising sovereignty issues, especially since New Delhi has been consistent about not violating Beijing's sovereignty in any manner.

Not only has China illegally occupied more than 43,000 sq km of Indian territory of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, including Aksai Chin and Shaksgam Valley, it has ramped up the construction of projects in these areas. India stopped referring to the "one-China" policy in official documents and pronouncements since 2011 only because Chinese authorities issued stapled visas to residents of the border regions of Arunachal Pradesh and J&K.

In this context, it's clear that repeated calls by Chinese leaders to put the border issue in its "appropriate place" as the two sides take forward relations in other spheres will not work in the long run. The Chinese approach doesn't foster real trust to build a foundation for durable security and stability along the frontier. There have been far too many flare-ups on the Line of Actual Control in recent years. Along with India's concerns on trade imbalance, restricted access to Chinese markets and unpredictable supply chains, China should take steps aimed at genuinely addressing the border issue.

The lingering impact of a 'super' El Niño

The effects of a weak and uneven monsoon could continue beyond September. The next concern is heat. At about 1.5°C of global warming, a powerful El Niño could make 2027 a record-breaking heat year

Anyone who watched Argentina's football World Cup matches (before the final with Spain) would understand India's monsoon this year. For long stretches, Argentina's goals would not come. Then came a rush of late goals that changed the scoreline. The monsoon has followed a similar pattern.

June ended with rainfall about 40% below normal, making it India's fifth-driest June since record-keeping began in 1901. Rain returned in heavy bursts in early July, with places like Mahabaleshwar and Lonavala recording close to 1,000 mm in just 48 hours. In an extraordinary event on July 23, Umergam in Gujarat's Valsad district received 1,064 mm of rain in 24 hours, the third-highest daily rainfall ever recorded in India. The national deficit narrowed to 15% by July 26.

This is a monsoon of contrasts. Several

weeks of weak rain can be followed by a few days of intense downpours. Areas waiting for rain can suddenly face floods and crop damage, while other regions remain dry. Heavy rain can change the national rainfall average, but cannot quickly restore soil moisture or groundwater storage lost during weeks of weak rain.

The impact is visible in agriculture. By July 17, kharif sowing had covered about 658 lakh hectares, around 42 lakh hectares, or 6%, less than at the same time last year. Pulses, coarse cereals, oilseeds, and cotton were about 15%, 11%, 6%, and 6% behind last year, respectively. Rain can allow delayed sowing to results, but another break can damage young plants. Heavy rain returning later can cause waterlogging. For farmers, the monsoon rain matters as much as the seasonal total.

A warmer climate is sharpening these contrasts. For every degree Celsius warmer, the atmosphere can hold about 7% more water vapour. This does not mean rain increases evenly. When a suitable weather system forms, more moisture has been piled up, and the period. Warming raises the potential for heavier downpours, while monsoon winds determine where and when they occur.

The rapidly strengthening El Niño is adding to the concern. El Niño develops when the tropical Pacific becomes unusually

warm, altering winds and rainfall across the tropics. For India, it generally weakens the monsoon circulation and raises the likelihood of below-normal seasonal rainfall. However, it does not stop extreme rain. A weak monsoon can still contain short bursts of very heavy rainfall, particularly when the seas around India are warm.

This El Niño is developing unusually early and rapidly. The strongest event observed so far, in 2015-16, peaked near 2.75°C. The latest forecasts indicate that the current El Niño could peak near 2°C.

If that happens, it would surpass every El Niño in the observational record. We do not have a formal category such as "Super El Niño" in scientific circles, but that is what this event is shaping up to be. As global warming accelerates and extremes continue to break records, we may soon find ourselves scrambling for new names to describe these monster events.

El Niño forecasts are also better than before. Satellites, ocean buoys and climate models now track surface warming and the heat below the Pacific giving us several months of warning. These advances provide time for informed planning and preparation.

El Niño is part of a natural cycle, but it is developing in an ocean already carrying record amounts of heat from the sun. This could mean some of the hottest months and seasons yet experienced, with severe heatwaves,

Roxy Mathew Koll

is a climate scientist at the Indian Institute of Tropical Ecology and a lead author and reviewer of recent IPCC reports. The views expressed are personal

Pakistan's restive borders result from its crackdowns

"It is not over till it's over," goes a popular aphorism. In Pakistan, this applies not just to the insurgency in Balochistan — intermittent since 1948 — or the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) since 2001, but also to Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK). The last episode in PoK, which gathered momentum in early June, somewhat quietened after security forces killed nine people on July 14. However, the chief minister's car was recently greeted by a hostile crowd. This makes PoK the third unstable border province in Pakistan.

International-relations theory holds that a State's borders frame its sovereignty and legal existence. Against this backdrop, as each disenchanted party supports the other, Pakistan's peripheries are facing erosion. The protests in "Azad Kashmir" were centred in and around Rawalakot, the same area where rebellion broke out between 1950 and 1956, when Sardar Ibrahim's government was dismissed. Belonging to an elite Sudhan family, Ibrahim took on the Pakistani State by forming a separate government, from Rawalakot and Panderi. Local forces were helped against the Indian soldiers, who took some 150 policemen hostage. Eventually, the Pakistani forces launched a brutal crackdown and ended Ibrahim's revolt. Protesters, however, went on and over the years till 2024, before they broke out this June.

The recent protests were also led by a Sudhan, Sardar Aman Khan, from Panderi. Meanwhile, the intervals between such protests are getting shorter. For now, calm has been restored with local officials reaching out to Islamabad bringing in British Pakistani Qamar Raza, who is the head of the Overseas Pakistanis Foundation, to lower tensions. But, the chaos is sure to rise again — the 80,000-plus who hit the streets are not going to give up easily. Protesters, now and earlier, have long demanded opening of trade routes to India, which the Pakistani State sees as a political threat to the "border".

In Gilgit-Baltistan, unrest had been rising since April, with protests for constitutional rights just before "general elections". The Awami Action Committee, a grassroots organisation in the region, demanded replacing the Gilgit-Baltistan Assembly with a constituent assembly, free electricity from the Diamer-Bhaskar Dam in addition to 80% royalty, banning mining leases for non-locals (read Chinese) and reopening of "historic trade routes" (including the road to Kargil). Eventually, the Pakistani People's Party (PPP) won the elections, but all it did was pose a resolution asking that Gilgit-Baltistan be given all the privileges of mainland Pakistan, including federal funding like other provinces, constitutional rights and, most importantly, representation in the Federal Parliament — all of this "without prejudice" to Pakistan's "legal position" in the Kashmir dispute.

Simply put, it can't be done, and the PPP knows it. Granting this would imply full inclusion as a "fifth province", which, in turn, will require the Pakistani Constitution to be changed. So, what the PPP did was offer a sop, nothing more.

Meanwhile, ethnic groups such as the Ladakhis in Baltistan and the Balawaristan National Front are demanding a slew of rights. The Uyghur issue also simmers, with

China far from happy with Pakistan, which means clouds over another sensitive periphery.

From Islamabad's perspective, the Balochistan case remains the most tense. All districts, particularly Quetta and its peripheries, have been under general curfew since the reinforcements could not be sent to policemen in the attack on a police post at Ziarat on July 6 indicated a loss of control. Nine police personnel were killed immediately, while 10 others were killed after being kidnapped by the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP). Commentators note that policemen begging for ammunition received nothing and that the bodies of those killed were brought back by relatives rather than agencies. Protests by their families were called off after the local administration announced token measures, such as renaming roads after the "martyrs". Local units never step out of the "safe" cantonment areas and camps. The border is rife with smuggling of petrol, with hundreds of trucks entering from Iran. Locals have long asked for control of the border but to no avail. Graft and embezzlement are rampant among army generals heading the Frontier Corps here. One instance of this was the arrest of General Qasimullah Khan, who was dismissed in 2016, accused of having amassed 15 billion Pakistani rupees (PKR) through corruption. A secure "border" in terms of a well-manned and thoroughly

policed line, doesn't exist. A similar situation exists in Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa (KP); Pakistan's army chief, Asim Munir, recently warned that security personnel involved in cross-border smuggling will be arrested and court-martialed; the border is marked by illegal drug trade and smuggling of sugar and wheat into Afghanistan.

Munir didn't mention narcotics trafficking, but the TTP did, issuing a warning recently against trafficking and lack of basic governance, indicating its strong local identity. TTP cadres are recruited from the tribal areas, with training camps alleged to be in Afghanistan, challenging the writ of the Pakistani State. Here as well, the border has eroded to an extent where it is difficult to ascertain the area over which the State still exercises "control". In the wake of the brutal assault on a chief minister by his own police.

The most dangerous trend now is that all these dissonances are coalescing. Delegation from KP tried to join the PoK protesters; Baloch activists came out in support as well. Continuing reports indicate cooperation between Baloch and Pashtun groups, though their ideologies differ vastly. In short, the entire border of more than 4,500 km is in danger; only the settled border with India is stable. Warning neighbours such as Iran and Afghanistan have worsened the situation for Pakistan. Meanwhile, Rawalakot remains a prime army recruitment area, with several senior generals from the Sudhan tribe. As Pakistan's peripheries erode, the one thing holding the country together, by force is its army. In sum, the entire situation is one of cause-and-effect — the Pakistani State can either choose to keep its territories intact or it can continue with its violent cross-border smuggling. The latter is the only choice it has.

Tara Khatra is a former director, National Security Council Secretariat. The views expressed are personal

RAJNATH SINGH | DEFENCE MINISTER

There will be no talks with Pakistan other than on PoK, a part of India which it occupied illegally

In his address at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras, on Kargil Vijay Diwas

STRAIGHTFORWARD

Shashi Shekhar

Questions for society after the student protest ended

The "cockroaches" have left Jantar Mantra after the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan, the education minister. Their successful movement brought back memories of the Indian youth politics where students weren't mere voters but also the first line of resistance against injustice and oppression. These youngsters have shown that they aren't a crowd but a wave that has the capacity to bring about huge change.

What's the permanent solution to the pressing issue riling the youth? There are no easy answers. The problem is buried under impermanent layers of difficulties. Let me take you five decades earlier to make my point clearer. It was the beginning of summer in 1975. I reached the examination centre at an Inter College in Mainpuri, Uttar Pradesh, to appear for the Class X board exams. I saw about a dozen boys trying to break bricks into small pieces right outside the room where I was to give my examination. They stuffed their pant pockets with those broken brick pieces and entered the room. As soon as the question papers were distributed, they tied theirs to those brick pieces and threw these outside. After some time, the same pieces landed back in the college premises. The machines made such operations easier. Let me take you five decades earlier to make my point clearer. It was the beginning of summer in 1975. 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{ CASPIAN SEA }

Iran vows revenge after Kyiv hits ship

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

TEHRAN: Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Sunday warned that his country would respond to a deadly attack by Ukraine on an Iranian ship in the Caspian Sea.

It came after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said Kyiv had carried out long-range strikes in the Caspian Sea against vessels transporting military cargo involving Iran, underscoring the increasingly international dimensions of Russia's war in Ukraine.

"Zelensky has attacked an Iranian commercial vessel, killing a sailor," Araghchi said on X, describing it as "a blatant UN Charter violation done at Israel's behest to drag Europe into its war".

He added that, during calls with the European Union's Kaja Kallas and Russian top diplomat Sergei Lavrov, he "made clear that what the free-loader in Kyiv did CANNOT GO UNANSWERED".

Iran's foreign ministry said the attack caused the ship "to explode, killing one sailor and injuring several others".

The Islamic republic "has never intervened in the conflict between Russia and Ukraine", the ministry said in a statement.

On Saturday, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said on social media that armed forces had achieved "very strong results with long-range strikes in the Caspian Sea — including vessels used in military cargo shipments involving Iran, as well as a warship".

Ukraine's intelligence services, for their part, reported on Telegram that drone attacks had been carried out against "cargo vessels under international sanctions that were used to transport military cargo



US forces enforce the naval blockade against Iran.

Oil tanker explodes after hitting naval mine in Strait of Hormuz

Agencies
letters@hindustantimes.com

DUBAI/TEHRAN: An oil tanker exploded in the Strait of Hormuz after colliding with a naval mine, Iran's semi-official Tasnim news agency reported on Sunday, Reuters reported.

Tasnim said the tanker struck the mine after leaving the route designated by Iran in the strategic waterway. There was no immediate official statement from Iranian authorities regarding the incident.

Tasnim said Iran had "repeatedly warned beforehand that if ships deviate from Iran's designated route, they would bear the conse-

quences themselves", ANI reported. Iranian authorities had not officially commented on the reported incident at the time of publication.

'Fully prepared for all scenarios': Iran Army ahead of Bibi's US visit
Iran said its Army is "fully prepared for all scenarios" and has strengthened its air defence capabilities ahead of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's visit to the United States, according to Iranian media. As reported by ISNA news agency, Iran Army said that the US had failed to achieve its objectives during the conflict and suggested US was reassessing its strategy, ANI reported.

between Iran and Russia".

According to Iranian state television, the foreign ministry summoned the Ukrainian charge d'affaires in Tehran on Saturday to protest this "hostile and criminal act".

And in a conversation with the European Union's foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas, Araghchi called for a "firm response" by the EU and the United Nations Security Council to this attack, IRNA added.

{ WOMAN KILLED IN TERROR ATTACK }

Man plows car into Berlin Pride crowd, killed after hrs-long hunt

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

BERLIN: The suspect in the deadly Berlin Pride attack that left one person dead and 29 injured was shot and killed by police during a confrontation on Sunday in a suburb of the city, authorities said.

Abdul Ballout, a German citizen with Lebanese roots, was killed following a search that lasted nearly 24 hours after the attack in downtown Berlin. Prosecutors said he had previously sought to join the militant Islamic State group.

Ballout was suspected of driving a van into a crowd near Berlin's Pride festival Saturday night before apparently stabbing others with a machete in what authorities believe was an Islamic extremist terror attack.

"Everything we see here points to us dealing with an Islamic terror attack," interior minister Alexander Brundt said. He put the total number of



The vehicle which crashed into the crowd; (inset) the suspect, Abdul Ballout.

wounded at 29. The attack occurred a few hundred metres from a party near the Brandenburg Gate that was supposed to close out the city's Pride festival.

Ballout was born in Germany, the minister said. His mother was naturalised in 2002, three years before he was born. Ball-

out travelled to Lebanon in 2005 with the goal of going to Syria to join the Islamic State group, Berlin prosecutors said Sunday.

There, he made contact with several people who were presumed members of the militant group — or at least he believed them to be, prosecutors said. He

was arrested in Lebanon last year and sentenced by a military court to three months' imprisonment for offenses including incitement to religious and sectarian conflict.

He returned to Germany after completing his sentence, where he was arrested at the Berlin airport. In May, a juvenile court in Berlin convicted Ballout of preparing a serious act of violence endangering the state, as well as publishing Islamic State propaganda on his Instagram account and other charges, prosecutors said. The court handed down a suspended sentence of 1 year but later released him.

According to police, a white van drove into the Tiergarten park around 10pm and hit several people before colliding with a tree. The closing party at the Pride festival, known as Christopher Street Day, was ongoing at the time next to the Brandenburg Gate, a short distance away.

Police said a woman was killed.

VIETNAM SHIP IN SOUTH CHINA SEA SINKS, 17 MISSING

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

HANOI: A multinational search by Vietnamese, Philippine and Chinese rescuers was underway on Sunday for 17 crew members missing after a cargo ship sank in bad weather off a Chinese-occupied shoal in the disputed South China Sea.

The Vietnamese cargo vessel Khoi Nguyen 18, carrying 62 people, sank late Saturday near Fiery Cross Reef, which is a Chinese-built island and a military outpost in the hotly contested Spratly Islands. Of those on board, 45 crew members have been found and 17 others are still reported missing.

The vessel "sank while operating in bad weather".

Six civilians killed as Ukraine and Russia exchange strikes

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com

KYIV: Russian ballistic missiles struck the Ukrainian capital of Kyiv early on Sunday, setting off fires and wounding at least three civilians, while attacks on other parts of the country later killed at least two people, local officials said. The strikes came as Ukraine's successful drone attacks have stalled the Russian army's advances in an expanded campaign inside Russia that has been causing fuel shortages and piling pressure on Russian leader Vladimir Putin.

In Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine, Kremlin-installed authorities said a Ukrainian



Firefighters at a site hit by a Russian drone strike in Ukraine.

drone strike had killed four civilians in the city of Horlivka. According to Ivan Prihodko, the city's Russian-appointed mayor, the city had been under

fire since the early hours of Sunday. Russian forces overnight struck down 133 Ukrainian drones over Russia, the Black Sea and Crimea.

HT

Indian-origin man's family urge reforms year after suicide

HOUSTON: The family of Indian-origin medical student Vaidhyan Duggal, 24, who died by suicide following an academic disciplinary action in Texas is seeking legal review and policy reforms, alleging a lack of mental health safeguards and institutional failure. He died while completing third year at Texas Tech University Health Sciences Centre.

US probes after video shows man kicking sea lion

SAN DIEGO: Federal wildlife authorities are investigating after a video appeared to show a person kicking a protected sea lion at a beach in California. The video shows a person kicking the animal while another laughs in the background.

10 killed after typhoon makes landfall in China

BEIJING: Ten people were killed in rain-triggered floods in China as Typhoon Noul made landfall early Sunday in Guangdong. Noul, the 12th and the strongest typhoon to hit China so far this year. A flash flood hit a scenic area in Wuyuan.

China univ probes girl's death in gene-editing trial

BEIJING: A Chinese university is looking into reports that a gene-editing trial caused the death of a six-year-old girl, which was not disclosed in published research, the school said on Sunday. The girl died last year after receiving a spinal infusion.

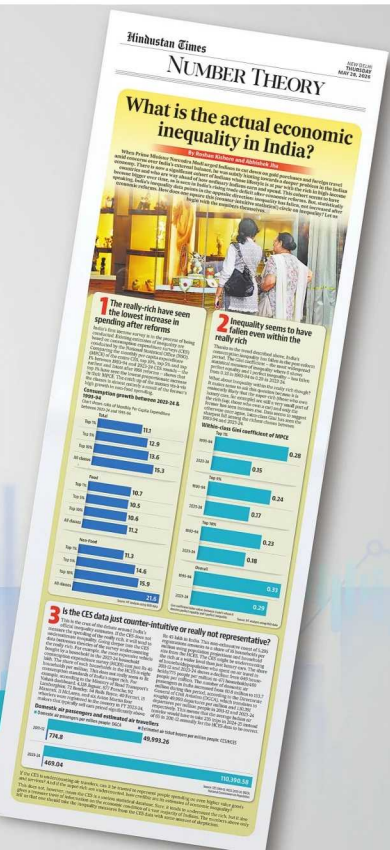
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Champion delivers again



MAJOR ACHIEVEMENTS

COMMONWEALTH GAMES	OLYMPICS	WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS
SILVER 2014 Glasgow	SILVER 2021 Tokyo	SILVER 2022 Bogota
GOLD 2018 Gold Coast	GOLD 2027 Anaheim	SILVER 2025 Forde
GOLD 2022 Birmingham		
GOLD (48kg) 2026 Glasgow		

TOP SHOWING
CAREER BEST LIFT: 205kg (Asian C'ships 2021, Tashkent)
COMMONWEALTH GAMES RECORD: 190kg (Glasgow 2026)

Sublime Chanu completes golden hat-trick in Glasgow

The Tokyo Olympics silver medalist lifter sets Games records in snatch, clean and jerk and total for her third CWG gold in a row

Shantanu Srivastava
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A brief hiccup notwithstanding, there was a degree of pre-ordained certainty about Mirabai Chanu as she stepped up to lift the barbell at SEC Armadillo in Glasgow on Sunday.

Having begun her Commonwealth Games journey in the Scottish city back in 2014 when she won silver as a fresh-faced 19-year-old, Chanu has since become the undisputed queen of Indian weightlifting, winning every medal there is — except at the Asian Games — and ensuring her legacy in Indian sport. Commonwealth Games were never supposed to test her. Chanu and coach Vijay Sharma have that elusive Asian Games medal firmly in their sights for which they'll be in Japan in two months. On Sunday, the 31-year-old lifter ensured she left the platform with multiple records in 48kg division.



India's Rishikant Singh celebrates after winning silver.

The snatch record fell first, then the clean and jerk, and that accounted for a new mark in total lift. The top finish completed her golden hat-trick at CWG, following wins in Gold Coast (2018) and Birmingham (2022).

Chanu entered a CWG record of 82kg as her opening weight in snatch, but uncharacteristically failed. Unperturbed, she returned to lift that weight and set the record. She went three kg up in her final snatch attempt and succeeded, setting a new Commonwealth and CWG record.

In clean and jerk round, Chanu again entered a CWG record of 105 kg but couldn't complete the lift on the first try. She

returned to correct the anomaly, bearing in triumph as she aggregated a commanding 190kg (85kg in snatch and 105kg in clean and jerk). Mirabai has cut down 2.5kg to make the weight. It is not easy. That is why she didn't go too hard in this competition," Sharma said, explaining how she went about the lifts. A measure of her dominance can be gauged from silver medalist Ruth Asquith Nyong of Nigeria finishing with a total lift of 168kg, 22kg less than Mirabai.

Malaysia's Irene Jane Henry took bronze (67kg). Chanu has won India's first gold of the Games. It was India's second medal of the day, both in lifting, and third overall, following para powerlifter

Jhandu Kumar's bronze.

Standing atop the podium, Chanu yelled up. "Watching the Indian flag go up and hearing our national anthem made me a little emotional. They were tears of joy because I had won the first gold medal for India in this Games," she said. Having come down to 48kg, Chanu revealed her struggle to reduce weight. "When I used to compete in 48kg, I didn't have to be quite as strict with control, but 48kg is a real battle. Maintaining that body weight is a huge challenge. Since this was my last Commonwealth Games in 48kg, I told myself I could do it. For an athlete, controlling body weight is often the toughest fight. Just paid close attention to my diet and kept telling myself I could pull it off."

The three-time Olympian will compete in 48kg at the Asian Games after which she'll move up to 53kg for the 2028 IA Olympics. "We'll take it as it comes," Sharma said over phone from Glasgow. "Our main target was the Asian Games. That's one medal missing from her cabinet."

Despite the commanding win, Sharma acknowledged it wasn't a flawless outing. "She missed her first lift in snatch and clean and jerk. It shouldn't have happened. We set high standards for ourselves and such lapses shouldn't

happen. There was a lapse in concentration, but we'll address that in training."

Chanu's fellow Manipur lifter Rishikant Singh won silver in men's 60kg. The 28-year-old matched the CWG record in snatch with 121kg to enter the clean and jerk competition in the lead. However, he managed only 143kg after failing in his last two attempts, finishing with a total of 264kg. Malaysia's Mohammad Aniq Kasdan took gold with a Games record 152kg in clean and jerk for a total of 273kg. Kenya's Joshua Amunga took bronze (260kg). Rishikant later revealed that a knee injury suffered a week before competition resurfaced during clean and jerk, robbing him of the power needed to complete his heavier lifts.

Swimmers in final

In swimming, the Indian men's 4x200m freestyle relay team qualified for the eighth-team final after finishing third in their heat. Shaikh Shashankumar, Anesh Sunil Kumar Gowda, Aryan Nehra and Sriharri Nataraj clocked 7:39.48 to finish behind Australia and England in their heat, qualifying sixth fastest overall.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

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RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)



ARTISTIC GYMNASTICS
Men's all-around final
Tapan Mohanty finished 15th
Women's all-around final
Pranati Nayak, Nishika Agarwal, Protistha Samanta, Eshita Rewale
All failed to qualify

BOWLS
Women's pairs, Group B
India lost to Namibia in tie-breaker
India vs England
India lost to England in tie-breaker

Men's singles, Group D
Putul Sonowal lost to Shaun James Parris (MLT)

BOXING
Women's 54kg Round of 16
Preeti Pawar bt Deborah Mtenje (MAW) RSC

Men's 55kg Round of 16
Jadamani Singh bt Sumama Rehman (PAK)

SWIMMING
Men's 4x200m freestyle relay heats
India qualified for final

WEIGHTLIFTING
Men's 60kg
Rishikant Singh won silver

Women's 48kg
Mirabai Chanu won gold

GLASGOW CORNER

RAMSAY-PEATY BOUNCES BACK

Adam Ramsay-Peaty bounced back from his tearful CWG disappointment as he qualified for the semi-finals of the men's 50-metre breaststroke on Sunday. Former Olympic champion Ramsay-Peaty was back in the pool less than 24 hours after breaking down in tears after only taking a bronze medal in the 100m breaststroke. Since the 2022 CWG, Ramsay-Peaty had taken time off due to mental health issues and also endured a family rift following his marriage to Holly Ramsay in December. Frustrated by his failure to perform, the English swimmer said: "I'm not crying because it's a bronze. I'm crying because I know that the swim could have been better, and I know I worked way better than that."

GYMNAST RELEASED FROM HOSPITAL
English gymnast Gabriel Langton has been released from hospital after a frightening fall during the team final. The 18-year-old received extensive treatment before being stretched from the arena after missing a grab during his high bar routine and landing on his head and neck. "Gabriel was transferred to the hospital as a precautionary measure and underwent multiple scans today, with very positive results," England team manager said in a statement. "Thankfully, he has been cleared of any serious injury complications and will be discharged to return to the team hotel this evening."

SCOTLAND'S WARD WINS GYMNASTICS
Reuben Ward struck gold for hosts Scotland in the men's gymnastics all-around final. Ward was devastated as Scotland narrowly missed out on the podium in the team final on Friday, but more than made amends to win his nation's first medal in the men's all-around event at a Commonwealth Games. The 21-year-old held off a charge from Canada's Felix Dolt to secure gold by just 0.20 of a point with Australia's Jesse Moore in third. "I knew I could do it, but to actually do it. When the score came through, it's just jubilation and joy," said Ward. "Incredible! I'm so lucky to be in this position. I would've been there in this position without my team-mates."

medalstally

COUNTRY	Gold	Silver	Bronze	Total
1 Australia	13	7	11	31
2 England	4	7	5	16
3 Scotland	4	2	0	6
4 Nigeria	3	4	0	7
5 South Africa	2	2	3	7
7 INDIA	1	1	1	3

TELL MIDNIGHT

Boxer Parveen eyes fresh start after whereabouts ban

Rutvik Mehta
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MUMBAI: When things get hazy in the mind, Parveen Hooda gets down to writing in her diary. Around mid-2025, while the boxer was serving a doping suspension due to a whereabouts failure, she could neither see a road ahead nor figure out why she kept training. And so, she went back to her diary, spelling out her main targets for the next few years. For 2026, I wrote Commonwealth Games and Asian Games — that I have to be there and represent the country again," she said.

At Hooda's last multi-sport event, the 2023 Hangzhou Asian Games, she secured the 57kg bronze medal and a quota for the 2024 Paris Olympics. Two months ahead of what would have been her debut Games, she was banned for three whereabouts failures.

Serving a backdated 14-month suspension from May 2024 with her Asian ban scratched, Hooda wondered if she would ever be able to return to such a stage.



Parveen Hooda.

"All through last year, I prayed that somehow I get a chance to represent India in an event like this again. Now that I'm finally here at the CWG, it feels so good," she said. The feeling through these months of inaction was more of fear. "Of whether I would be able to come back at all or not."

From being close to her peak in 57kg when she was banned, Hooda had to halt, pause, reset and start from scratch again. "It was very challenging," she said. "When you have no competitions to aim for, you don't know what to train for. And even if you train, the motivation is largely gone."

comeback. So, the only solution I found was to not give up. I didn't want to live in guilt all my life."

Along with her family, she moved from her village in Bihar, Haryana to Rohat to train "without any distractions". A shoulder injury kept her away for three months during the suspension before Hooda made her competitive return last October in 60kg.

A gold on her international return at the World Boxing Cup Finals gave her the belief that "I still belong here and that next year I could aim for big things". However, with a spot in 60kg already taken, Hooda had to move up to 65kg. "It was a little difficult initially, especially since there was a difference of 5kg straight. I had to suddenly turn a lot of my attention to strength and diet."

Strength training went up from twice a week to three, and protein was increased in her diet. A natural counter-attacker, Hooda made technical adjustments for taller and stronger opponents.

Eyes on Sreeshankar, Shirse in athletics

Shantanu Srivastava
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NEW DELHI: The 32-member Indian athletics squad will get to work in Glasgow starting Monday as track and field events — among the few disciplines that still offer quality competition at the Commonwealth Games — get rolling. India's able-bodied squad comprises 22 male and 10 female athletes while 10 para athletes will also bid to boost the medal tally.

India's athletes enter the competition on the back of a fruitful home season that was followed by a 45-day training and condition camp in Spala, Poland where bulk of the able-bodied squad trained. Neeraj Chopra arrived in Glasgow from his training base in Switzerland while woman distance runner Parul Chaudhary tuned up in Ooty.

India will hope to better their eighth-medal haul in athletics from Birmingham 2022, and for good reason. A sizeable number of the athletes enter the competition after setting credible national records and meet records barely 60 days back.

When Athletics Federation of India (AFI) announced CWG qualifying standards earlier this year, there was consternation in the Indian camp. As many as 15 events demanded that Indian athletes better the national record, while two competitions — women's 100m and women's high jump —



India long jumper Murali Sreeshankar.

required athletes to equal existing records. Indian athletes responded by producing a summer to remember. The Federation Cup held in May saw Nis set in men's 100m, 400m, and pole vault, while decathlete Tejvir Singh Shankar became the first Indian to enter the 800m pole vault. Long jumper Murali Sreeshankar reinforced his consistency with steady 8m-plus

event features 77 athletes across 11 heats with Gurindervir boasting of the second fastest season's best among them.

Jamaican Rohan Watson, with a personal best of 9.39secs and a season's best of 10.05secs, is expected to be Gurindervir's toughest challenger on paper although it will be interesting to see how well he has adjusted to cold Glasgow. Chopra mentioned the weather on Sunday.

"It's definitely cold here and the conditions are tough. But we need to be mentally strong and not let about the conditions because ultimately they are the same for everyone," the double Olympics and world's medalist said.

While Gurindervir is making his CWG debut, India will hope Sreeshankar uses his vast experience in the long jump pit. The 27-year-old with a personal best of 8.41m is a medal favourite, having bounced back remarkably from a ruptured patellar tendon on his left knee.

His take-off leg — that required surgery — "I can't expect my knee to be at 100 percent because the surgery was a very serious one. Thankfully, I am in my best shape. I am able to manage the knee better," Sreeshankar told HT before leaving for the Spala camp. A CWG silver medalist from 2022, he will hope to go a level higher.

"I have the experience of competing in the UK. Conditions in

Stetted in Group A that features 10 jumpers, Sreeshankar has the season's best (8.38m) as well as the personal best among them. India's other long jump entry is Lokeshkumar, who has the season's best leap of 8.21m, achieved twice this year in the USA.

The Indian duo will be wary of Tejay Gayle of Jamaica, a 2019 world champion and a three-time Worlds medalist. He comes to Glasgow in red-hot form, having jumped 8m or above in nine of his 11 competitions this year.

Tejas Shirse, the 110m hurdler who bettered his national record about 45 days back at the Indian Athletics Series 9 in Ludhiana clocking 13.7secs, will be another Indian to keep an eye on. Competing in his first CWG, Shirse has the season's fastest timing among those who will take Lane 7 in Heat 1. The 15 men competing in the two heats, only Jamaican Demario Prince has done better this season (13.0secs). Whether that translates into something special, we'll know on Monday. The first three in each heat and the next two best qualified athletes will advance to the final that will be held later in the day.

Ht

Aishwary, Niraj fail to finish on podium

HANGZHOU: World championship silver medalist Aishwary Prasad Singh Tomar and Niraj Kumar both advanced to the men's 50m rifle 3-positions final at the ISSF World Cup but failed to bag podium finishes. Aishwary ended sixth with 314.3 points, while Niraj finished seventh on the medals table with just a solitary silver.

Dagar ends T16 in Scottish Open

NEW DELHI: India's Dilsha Dagar finished tied 16th in the women's Scottish Open at Dundonald, on the Ladies European Tour on Sunday. Dilsha shot a final round one-over 73 to finish two-over for the event. She is currently sixth in the LET Order of Merit. Jenny Shin (9-under) of Korea won the event by two shots.

Malaysia to host Bahrain F1 GP in Oct

BUDAPEST: The Bahrain GP, which was cancelled in April due to the West Asia war, will be held in Malaysia from October 2-4. Formula One organisers announced.

U Mumba TT retain title beating Dempo

GOA: U Mumba TT produced a solid comeback to end Dempo Goa Challengers' unbeaten run and successfully defend their UTI title with an 8-5 victory in a gripping Grand Finale on Sunday. Trailing 4-2, Manush Shah and Anna Husey ignited the turnaround with a mixed doubles win.

Mature Sooryavanshi helps India cruise past Zimbabwe

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KOLKATA: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi hit a mature fifty and Mayank Yadav took 3/29 to headline India's comfortable 35-run victory against Zimbabwe in the third T20I at Harare on Sunday for a 3-0 series sweep.

Sooryavanshi's 81 off 49 balls was the cornerstone of India's 192 that proved comfortably above par on a surface where stroke-making became progressively harder. Ryan Burl scored a 43-ball 54 but Zimbabwe were never really in the hunt.

With 151 runs, he was declared Player-of-the-Series. However, for a change, this was an innings that underlined not just his power, but the 15-year-old's growing maturity.

There were flashes of the familiar Sooryavanshi though. Sikandar Raza's opening over yielded two boundaries despite the off-spinner extracting turn, while Blessing Muzarabani's extra pace disappeared over long leg courtesy of a breathtaking hook. But unlike many of his previous T20 innings, this was not an all-out assault from the first ball. It was built on judgement as much as aggression.

Zimbabwe's quicks generated awkward bounce and repeatedly nailed the wide yorkers after the Powerplay.

Resisting the temptation to manufacture big shots, Sooryavanshi instead swayed under the bouncer, respected the yorkers and collected singles while waiting for scoring opportunities. His first 30 runs were as much about survival as domination.

India raced to 64/1 in the Powerplay before the surface slowed noticeably. The middle overs produced only 81 runs in nine overs as Zimbabwe's spinners varied their pace and lengths effectively.



India's Vaibhav Sooryavanshi plays a shot during the third T20I against Zimbabwe.

It was in this phase that Sooryavanshi demonstrated another dimension to his batting.

He picked his moments expertly. Wesley Madhevere was reverse-swept over third man and was driven straight for four off the next delivery. Against Raza, he adjusted brilliantly after charging down the pitch, converting what could have been a mis-cue into a 102-metre straight six.

Sooryavanshi's second T20I fifty came with a cut to deep point, after which he removed his gloves and formed the letter 'A' with his fingers in a gesture of gratitude to his mother Aarti. It was a restrained celebration that reflected the measured nature of his innings.

"I just tried to give my team a good start. What I do at practice, I try to replicate it in the match as well," Sooryavanshi told the broadcasters after the match. Ishan Kishan (29 off 26 balls) and Shreyas Iyer (27 off 18 balls) contributed useful cameos around him before Rinku Singh (25 off 14 balls) provided the finishing kick.

Sooryavanshi looked set for a maiden international hundred after smashing Madhevere into the stands to move into the 80s, only for Brad Evans to sprint in from long-off and complete a superb diving catch to end the innings on 81 from 49 balls, studied with eight fours and four sixes.

If Sooryavanshi laid the plat-

form, India's bowlers ensured there would be no drama in the chase. Mayank Yadav needed just one ball to make his mark, removing Brian Bennett with the opening delivery of the innings, immediately putting Zimbabwe on the back foot. Ben Curran and Dion Myers were unable to inject momentum during a subdued Powerplay before Yash Thakur struck twice in two balls, dismissing Myers and Raza to effectively end the contest. Burl fought a lone battle with a gritty fifty, but Zimbabwe were never able to threaten India's total.

Brief scores: India 192/5 (V Sooryavanshi 81, Kishan 29, B Evans 2/41), Zimbabwe 157/7 (R Burl 54, M Yadav 3/29, Y Thakur 2/45). **India won by 35 runs.**

Lando Norris grabs first race victory of season in Hungary

Agencies

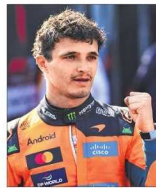
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BUDAPEST: World champion Lando Norris claimed his first win of the season and 12th of his career with a resounding triumph for McLaren ahead of Red Bull's Max Verstappen in Sunday's hooter-skitter Hungarian Grand Prix.

The 26-year-old Briton, who started from pole position but had to recover after a poor opening lap, came home 15 seconds clear of four-time world champion Verstappen with world championship leader Kimi Antonelli finishing third for Mercedes.

The Ferraris of Charles Leclerc and seven-time champion Lewis Hamilton ended up fourth and fifth ahead of Isaac Adaja in the second Red Bull, George Russell in the second Mercedes and Racing Bulls' Liam Lawson.

Nico Hülkenberg scored his first points of the season in ninth place for Audi ahead of rookie Arvid Lindblad in the second Racing Bulls. Norris repeated his success last season at the Hunga-



McLaren driver Lando Norris.

rring where McLaren have won for the last three years.

Antonelli's determined drive, in a frantic race of divergent tyre strategies, lifted him 50 points clear of Hamilton in the championship. "Beautiful," said Norris on team radio. "The car was unbelievable today! Flying! It's probably the best pace I've ever had," he said. "This track is good for us."

Verstappen was critical of his car, but happy to claim another podium finish. "I didn't expect it

today — we had to work very hard for this," he said.

Antonelli said it had been a hard race. "It was so tough to overtake, but it is the best result for me to go into the break and now we can keep pushing."

The race began in scorching heat with the highest temperatures of the weekend - 31 Celsius (air) and 51 (track).

Ferrari gambling on soft tyres for the start while all the started on mediums. Oscar Piastri made a fast start to pass Leclerc. When Norris went past at Turn Two and Piastri took the lead while Hamilton widened Leclerc for fourth behind Verstappen.

Behind them, the luckless Russell's Mercedes went into anti-stall on the grid. He fell from from sixth to 20th while teammate Antonelli advanced to sixth. Hamilton attacked Verstappen without success and by lap 10 was losing grip. "Max is slow," reported Hamilton, who pitted to "undercut" Verstappen on lap 14, rejoined 10th and stormed past Lindblad before Red Bull brought the Dutchman in on lap 15.

Preeti storms into CWG quarters

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GLASGOW: Asian Games bronze medalist boxer Preeti Pawar hardly broke a sweat as she stormed into the women's 54kg quarterfinals after a dominating win over Deborah Mtenje of Malawi in the Commonwealth Games here on Sunday.

The 22-year-old from Bhiwani, who won a bronze in the 2022 Asian Games as well as a gold in the New Delhi World Cup last year, toyed with her opponent before winning her round of 16 contest via Referee Stop Contest (RSC) decision in

the second round. The Malawi boxer faced two standing counts, one in each round, and it was enough for the referee to stop the bout with 47 seconds left in the second round.

Preeti got the unanimous nod of all the five judges in the first round. The win puts Preeti one victory away from securing her maiden Commonwealth Games medal.

She will face Northern Ireland's Nicole Clyde in the quarter-finals on Tuesday. Clyde secured a unanimous decision victory against Ghana's Nancy Bamfo in the pre-quar-

terfinals earlier in the day.

The two boxers are familiar with each other, having teamed together as sparring partners in Belfast ahead of the Games.

"It was my first bout and I wanted to check how I manage in the ring. I was feeling the environment of the ring in the first round before getting aggressive in the second," Preeti told PTI. "I have a good draw and I will give my best. Let's hope for a medal."

Later in the evening, India's Judamani Singh defeated Pakistani boxer Sunama Rehman 5-0 to enter the 55kg quarter-finals.

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